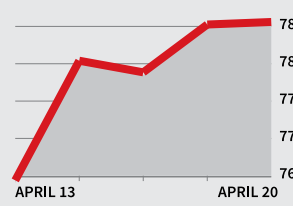


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 78520.30 (+26.76)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24364.85	+11.30
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.56	+0.01
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.12	+0.20
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	151487.00	+439
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	250675.00	+735

START-UP BOOST.

Karnataka has so far funded over 1,300 start-ups through various initiatives, says State's IT and Biotech Minister Priyank M Kharge **p12**



POLLSCAPE.

SIR, women's safety among key election campaign issues in West Bengal **p7**

SBI targets 'balance-sheet size of 25% of India's GDP by 2030'

BOTTOM-UP APPROACH. Plans to improve market share by 1 per cent in 800 districts

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

India's biggest bank wants to grow even bigger. State Bank of India (SBI) plans to expand its balance-sheet to about 25 per cent of the country's GDP by 2030 from about 20 per cent now.

The state-owned bank, which has been doubling its balance-sheet roughly every six years, is eyeing an improvement in its market share by one per cent in each of the 800 districts in the country in FY27 in the run up to its balance-sheet expansion goal, per plans laid out by the bank.

Each district will be treated as a distinct growth unit with strategies tailored to local opportunities, said senior executives versed with the bank's roadmap.

A bank's balance-sheet comprises capital (including tier-I and tier-II capital and reserves and surplus) and liabilities (deposits, borrowings and other liabilities and provisions) which are used to create assets (including loans and advances, investments, cash and balances with the RBI, balances with banks and money at call and short-notice, fixed and other assets).

As at December 2025 end, SBI's balance-sheet stood at ₹71.62 lakh crore.

The bank's total business (deposits: ₹57.01 lakh crore plus advances: ₹46.28 lakh crore) stood at ₹103.29 lakh crore. Further, its market share in deposits and ad-



GAINING MORE HEFT

- It has been doubling balance sheet every six years
- It will focus on "ABCD" (all branches to contribute to deposits)
- Activate at least 25% of unclaimed deposits
- Balanced approach to loan growth: Combining expansion in corporate segment with RAM
- SBI will deploy 'Seva Sarathis' (service guides) in 10,000 high footfall branches

vances stood at about 22 per cent and 20 per cent, respectively.

GLOBAL RANKING

The SBI's ambitious goal to grow its balance-sheet to about 25 per cent of the country's GDP comes even as it has already set its sights on moving up the ranking scale of global banks by market capitalisation.

In November 2025, Chairman Challa Sreenivasulu Setty said SBI aims to rank among the top 10 global banks on this metric against the then 27th position.

PUSH FOR DEPOSITS

To add heft to its business, on the liabilities front, SBI will pursue themes such as "ABCD" (all branches to contribute to deposits), activate at least 25 per cent of unclaimed deposits of ₹19,500 crore and tap Gen Z, young professionals and the emerging affluent segment, said the executives.

BALANCED LENDING

On the assets front, the bank will take a balanced approach, combining expansion in corporate segment along with traditional seg-



Challa Sreenivasulu Setty, Chairman, SBI

ments such as RAM (retail, agriculture and MSME), with a strong push towards end-to-end digital journeys.

Also in the works is a move to deploy "Seva Sarathis" (service guides) in 10,000 high footfall branches and identifying white spaces to expand its branch footprint.

Further, the lender will remove the distinction between home and non-home branches, enabling customers to undertake transactions at any branch.

NEW YONO APP

SBI is also setting much store by its new mobile banking app YONO 2.0, which was launched in 2025.

It expects to onboard and serve over 20 crore users (against about 10 crore now) in the next few years via YONO 2.0.

SBI currently serves about 53 crore customers, that is, every third Indian is its customer, via 23,125 domestic and 244 foreign branches/offices.

Fire at HPCL refinery in Rajasthan; inauguration by PM cancelled

Press Trust of India
Jaipur

A day before its scheduled inauguration by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, fire broke out at HPCL's Pachpadra refinery in Rajasthan's Balotra district on Monday, prompting the authorities to order a probe.

The scheduled dedication of the refinery to the nation by the Prime Minister on Tuesday has been postponed, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said, adding the new date will be announced in due course.

There were no reports of any casualties in the incident. Fire-tenders doused the blaze in around two hours, officials said.

The fire started in the vicinity of the crude distillation unit (CDU), leading to chaos as emergency response teams moved in to contain the blaze.

Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma's scheduled visit to the refinery on Monday was also cancelled, the officials said, adding that an assessment of the damage is underway.

[Read more p2](#)

'Nearly half of Indians have health cover; out-of-pocket costs still soar'

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Nearly half of India's population is now covered by health insurance, finds a survey report released on Monday by the Statistics Ministry.

However, the average out-of-pocket expenses (OOPE) per hospitalisation continue to remain high, topping ₹34,000 in private and charitable healthcare facilities.

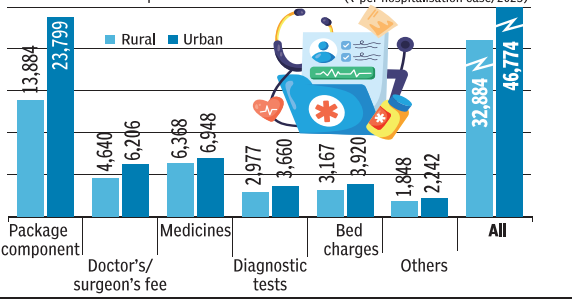
The findings are based on responses from about 1.4 lakh households surveyed between January and December 2025 as part of the 80th round of the National Sample Survey (NSS).

Health insurance coverage has risen sharply, the report noted. In 2017-18, during the previous NSS health survey, only 14.1 per cent of rural residents and 19.1 per cent of urban residents were insured.

By 2025, the coverage had increased to 47.4 per cent in rural and 44.3 per cent in urban areas. This expansion coincided with the reduction of GST on individual and family health insurance premiums to zero from 18 per cent, effective September 22, 2025.

Coverage under government-sponsored schemes grew even faster, rising from

Break-up of components in average medical expenditure



Source: MOSPI

13 per cent in rural areas and 9 per cent in urban areas in 2017-18 to 45.5 per cent and 31.8 per cent, respectively, in 2025. The Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PMJAY), launched in September 2018, offers annual health cover of up to ₹5 lakh per eligible household and has enrolled nearly 12 crore families.

Experts, however, offered a nuanced assessment of this expansion. "The increase is driven largely by government-funded health assurance schemes such as Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY rather than direct private insurance," said Indranil of OP Jindal University.

Mohan Rao, a former professor at the Centre of Social Medicine and Community Health, Jawaharlal Nehru University, added that the

scheme had effectively subsidised private healthcare provision at the cost of strengthening public health infrastructure.

OUT-OF-POCKET SPEND

Despite the wider coverage, cost disparities remain stark. The average OOPE per hospitalisation stood at ₹6,631 in public facilities, but jumped to ₹39,530 in charitable or NGO-run hospitals and ₹50,508 in private hospitals, including those empaneled under government schemes.

The 2017-18 NSS did not provide comparable OOPE estimates. However, a study by Indranil, which deflated costs to 2014 prices, estimated outpatient OOPE at ₹16,128 in rural and ₹20,814 in urban areas during that period.

QUICKLY.

WILL CEASEFIRE HOLD?
Peace talks under strain after US seizes Iran ship



Washington/Cairo: Concerns grew on Monday that the ceasefire between the US and Iran may not hold after the US said it had seized an Iranian cargo ship that tried to run its blockade, and Tehran vowed to retaliate. Iran said it would not participate in the second round of negotiations. **p3**

TURNAROUND SUPPORT
Govt to back Alliance Air with ₹460 crore loan

New Delhi: The Centre has approved over ₹460 crore in financial support for Alliance Air to help restore grounded aircraft and revive operations, sources told *businessline*. The aid is being extended as a loan, to be disbursed in three tranches linked to operational milestones. The first tranche of ₹150 crore has already been released, sources said. **p12**

CORPORATE GAPS

POSH complaints rise but under-reporting feared

Chennai: A year-on-year rise in POSH complaints among India's top listed companies points to better reporting awareness but also persistent corporate gaps. Complaints at Nifty 500 firms rose 13 per cent y-o-y to 2,583 in FY25. **p12**

Business Crosses ₹ 6 Lac Crores

Home Loan
@ **7.10%**

Car Loan
@ **7.45%**

Special Term Deposit
@ **7.15%**
Limited Period Offer For 400 Days

Business
17.47%

Advances
21.74%

Retail
32.39%

Vehicle Loan
55.51%

Deposits
14.14%

CASA
52.51%

AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER & YEAR ENDED MARCH 31, 2026 (₹ In Crore)

	Particulars	Quarter Ended 31/03/2026 (Audited)	Year Ended 31/03/2025 (Audited)	Year Ended 31/03/2026 (Audited)
RoA Qtr. 1.97% ↑	Total Income from Operations (Net)	8693.04	28401.62	32822.53
NIM (Domestic) Qtr. 3.95%	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	2329.09	5722.48	7857.37
Cost to Income Qtr. 37.08% ↓	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	2329.09	5722.48	7857.37
Gross NPA 1.45% ↓	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after Tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	2014.09	5519.79	7019.32
Net NPA 0.13% ↓	Paid up Equity Share Capital	7691.55	7691.55	7691.55
PCR 98.59% ↑	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) - as on date	23597.18	18903.46	23597.18
	Securities Premium Account	3867.25	3867.25	3867.25
	Net Worth	30272.42	25880.52	30272.42
	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt %*	17.05	25.19	17.05
	Debt** Equity Ratio	0.70	0.72	0.70
	Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) - not Annualized	2.62	7.48	9.13
	Capital Redemption Reserve	----	----	----

*Total Debts & Outstanding Debt represents total borrowings of the Bank.
**Debt represents borrowings with residual maturity of more than one year.

Note: The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 and 52 read with regulation 63(2) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 as amended. The full format of the Quarterly / Annual Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites (BSE: www.bseindia.com and NSE: www.nseindia.com) and Bank's website (www.bankofmaharashtra.bank.in)

Place: Pune
Date : 20/04/2026

Sushanta Kumar Mohanty
Executive Director

Prabhat Kiran
Executive Director

Nidhu Saxena
Managing Director & CEO

Bank of Maharashtra

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QUICKLY.

Tissot launches its e-comm platform in India



New Delhi: In a strategic move, Swiss watch brand Tissot has launched its e-commerce platform in India to expand its digital presence in the country and strengthen connect with a new generation of consumers while enhancing access to its product portfolio. This comes at a time when the brand's online sales have been growing steadily over the past few years. Tissot is the first brand from the Swatch Group to launch its own e-commerce platform in the country. Sylvain Dolla, CEO of Tissot, said: "India is one of the most dynamic markets in the world, and our commitment here continues to deepen. With our new e-commerce platform, we aim to get even closer to our customers, strengthening our relationship with them by offering a direct, seamless and trusted way to experience the Tissot universe." Tissot also unveiled its new Gentleman collection. **OUR BUREAU**

Auto component makers set for windfall as hybrid and electronics demand surges

CAFE III SHIFT. As norms tighten, incremental engine improvements will no longer suffice, forcing a change

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

The new fuel efficiency norms are set to unlock a multi-billion rupee opportunity for auto component makers as a mandatory technology upgrade shifts value from engines to electronics and hybrid systems. From start-stop systems to 48V hybrids, suppliers such as Bosch India, Uno Minda and Sona BLW Precision Forgings (Sona Comstar) are poised to benefit, alongside drivetrain players like Schaeffler India and Endurance Technologies, as auto-makers move to more efficient gearboxes. A broader structural shift is underway from standalone components to integrated systems, with the transition to more stringent WLTP testing, 15-20 per cent more demanding than current standards, requiring advanced solutions such as improved aerodynamics and low rolling resistance technologies. As compliance



THE TRANSITION. The CAFE III norms, spanning FY27 to FY32, are expected to drive supply-side investments of ₹61,500 crore to ₹1.48 lakh crore, much of which will flow into new components, systems and technologies rather than traditional engine upgrades

costs rise from ₹18,000-26,000 per vehicle initially to as much as ₹75,000-1.1 lakh by FY32, the share of electronics, hybrid systems and efficiency technologies in overall vehicle value is set to expand sharply, with additional upside from hybridisation benefiting battery makers such as Exide Industries and Amara Raja Energy. The CAFE III norms, spanning FY27 to FY32, are expected to drive supply-side investments of ₹61,500 crore to ₹1.48 lakh crore,

much of which will flow into new components, systems and technologies rather than traditional engine upgrades.

PHASE 1: VOLUME-LED From April 2027, even entry-level vehicles will require additional layered technologies to meet baseline targets. Start-stop systems alone could add ₹8,000-12,000 per vehicle, tyre pressure monitoring systems ₹3,000-6,000, and LED lighting another ₹2,000-4,000. These changes are expected to raise small

car prices by ₹20,000-35,000 in the initial phase, creating a high-volume opportunity for suppliers of electronics and efficiency-linked components.

VALUE SHIFT As norms tighten toward FY32, incremental engine improvements will no longer suffice, forcing a shift toward hybrid and electric systems. Mild hybridisation (48V), if required for mass-market vehicles, could increase component value per vehicle to

₹85,000-1.25 lakh. Stronger hybrids are expected to account for 7-8 per cent of the mix by FY32, while battery electric vehicles could reach 17-19 per cent, creating demand for electric motors, power electronics, battery packs, and management systems. Kotak estimates alternative powertrains, including EVs, hybrids, and CNG could account for 30-35 per cent of the market by FY32, significantly expanding the addressable market for such suppliers.

The transition is unlikely to be uniform. SUVs and heavier vehicles with tighter efficiency targets are to see faster adoption of strong hybrids and electric drivetrains, benefiting suppliers of higher-value components. Smaller cars will still require 9-14 per cent electrification to remain compliant, ensuring steady demand across segments. Regulatory mechanisms such as super-credits, particularly for EVs, are expected to accelerate sourcing of electrification-linked components.

Hyundai, TVS Motor formalise partnership for E3W commercialisation



RIDING TOGETHER. TVS Motor will co-develop the product using its leading-edge electric platform, extensive three-wheeler engineering expertise and deep local market knowledge

Our Bureau
Chennai

Hyundai Motor Company (Hyundai) and TVS Motor Company Ltd (TVS Motor) are partnering to capture a share of the growing electric three-wheeler market.

Hyundai and TVS Motor on Monday signed a Joint Development Agreement (JDA) to advance the development and commercialisation of Electric Three-Wheeler (E3W) solutions designed specifically to address India's last-mile mobility needs.

Under the agreement, Hyundai Motor will lead the design of and co-develop the E3W by leveraging its R&D expertise, advanced mobility technologies and human-centric design approach, the companies said in a joint statement.

TVS Motor will co-develop the product using its leading-edge electric platform, extensive three-wheeler engineering expertise and deep local market knowledge. TVS will also lead local sales, with its manufacturing operations in India catering to Indian market demand and future exports, as per the companies.

STRATEGIC DECISION "Our collaboration with TVS Motor is a strategic decision

rooted in that effort. We hope the co-developed E3W enables broader access to safer and more sustainable transportation for people across the country," Joongsun Ko, Senior Vice-President of Corporate Strategy & Planning at Hyundai Motor Company, said in a statement

SHARED AMBITION Sharad Mishra, President, Group Strategy, TVS Motor Company, said: "The JDA marks an important step in our partnership with Hyundai Motor Company and advances our shared ambition to develop electric three-wheeler solutions. By bringing together complementary strengths, including our E3W platform, engineering expertise, and deep understanding of customer needs, we are well-positioned to deliver purpose-built products for India and additional markets."

E3W CONCEPT The partnership was formalised following the successful presentation of the E3W concept at the Bharat Mobility Global Expo 2025, the companies said.

Both Hyundai and TVS Motor have established dedicated cross-functional teams to accelerate development timelines and the regulatory approval processes, the release said.

Fire at refinery site ahead of inauguration by PM, probe ordered

Press Trust of India
Jaipur

A fire broke out on Monday at the Pachpadra refinery in Rajasthan's Balotra district a day before its scheduled inauguration by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, prompting authorities to order a probe. The scheduled dedication of the refinery by the PM on April 21 has been postponed, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said, adding the new date will be announced in due course. There were no reports of any casualties in the incident. Fire tenders doused the blaze in around two hours, officials said. The fire started

in the vicinity of the crude distillation unit (CDU) section of the refinery, leading to chaos as emergency response teams moved in to contain the flames. Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma's scheduled visit to the refinery on Monday was also cancelled, the officials said, adding that an assessment of the damage is underway. "Due to an unfortunate fire incident today in the vicinity of the Crude Distillation Unit at the HRRL refinery, the scheduled dedication of the refinery by the Hon'ble Prime Minister on April 21, 2026, has been postponed. The fire has been brought under control and



there are no reports of any casualties. An investigation has been initiated," the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said on X. A revised date for the in-

auguration will be announced in due course, it added. The Congress alleged that the incident showed "safety lapses". "The Pachpadra refinery is

The fire started in the vicinity of the crude distillation unit of the refinery, leading to chaos as emergency response teams moved in to contain the flames

a matter of pride for all Rajasthanis. The incident at such a time is extremely unfortunate. I pray for everyone's safety," former Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot said.

Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Tika Ram Jolly termed the incident "serious and concerning" and questioned the State government's preparedness ahead of the high-profile event.

SAFETY LAPSES He alleged that the incident pointed to lapses in safety and accused the government of rushing the arrangements for the event. He also said there were "delays" in the project's execution. "This landmark project, with an investment of more than ₹79,450 crore, represents a significant milestone in India's energy and petrochemical sector," an official statement said earlier.

Mehli Mistry challenges Tata Trusts' move to amend Bai Hirabai Trust deed

Our Bureau
Mumbai



Former Tata Trusts trustee Mehli Mistry

Former Tata Trusts trustee Mehli Mistry has challenged Tata Trusts' bid to amend the eligibility clauses of the century-old Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution Trust deed, saying that the move to alter was itself an admission of the deed's clarity, with "no alternative interpretation" possible. He said the legal success for such an amendment appeared remote. The 1923 deed, said Mistry in a statement, unambiguously restricts trustees to "practising Zoroastrians residing in Mumbai or Navsari". "Tata Trusts' decision to seek alteration of the eligibility clauses of the 1923 Bai Hirabai trust deed is, in itself, an acknowledgment that the deed clearly and unambiguously restricts trust-

eeship to practising Zoroastrians residing in Mumbai or Navsari. The plain language of the deed admits of no alternative interpretation," the statement said.

BOARD'S LEGITIMACY It questioned the current board's legitimacy. Composed of "non-practising or non-Zoroastrian" individuals, it violated the deed's terms and Mistry demanded reconstitution "strictly in

compliance with its provisions". He said Bai Hirabai Trust's assets included a Zoroastrian fire temple, whose religious significance imposes stringent constraints on relaxing eligibility rules. Any change would necessitate an application to the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner, involving hearings for all stakeholders. Any order passed thereafter could only apply prospectively, not retrospectively, he added. For verification, Mistry said, trustees need only produce Aadhaar cards and sworn affidavits attesting to their practising Zoroastrian status in Mumbai or Navsari: "Failure or reluctance to furnish such basic documentation gives rise to serious concerns and warrants appropriate scrutiny." On Sunday Tata Trusts said it would scrap the eligibility restrictions in the Bai Hirabai Trust deed to make it inclusive.

'Consumer sector sees 146 deals in Q1'

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

India's consumer and retail sector recorded 146 merger and acquisition deals valued at \$1.5 billion in the March quarter, including one public market transaction. This reflects a strong recovery in deal volumes alongside a sharp moderation in values, a report by Grant Thornton Bharat noted.

While deal volumes increased 21 per cent from 120 to 146 deals, deal values declined 59 per cent from \$3.4 billion to \$1.4 billion.

The report noted that this indicated a continued shift towards smaller, strategic transactions in the absence of large-ticket deals. Naveen Malpani, Partner and Consumer Industry Leader, Grant Thornton Bharat, said: "Q1 2026 reflects a phase of measured recovery in India's consumer and retail sector, with deal volumes rebounding even as capital deploy-

ment remains selective. We are seeing a clear shift towards profitability-led growth, premiumisation and brand-led strategies, with investors focusing on resilient segments with pricing power. Categories such as personal care and food processing continue to attract strong interest, driven by evolving consumer preferences around health, convenience and premium offerings alongside continued portfolio sharpening by both domestic and global players."

M&A: Volume & value trends						
Deal summary	Volume			Value (\$ million)		
	Q3 2025	Q4 2025	Q1 2026	Q3 2025	Q4 2025	Q1 2026
Domestic	19	29	29	610	376	271
Inbound	-	2	2	-	25	10
Outbound	5	3	9	345	131	77
Total M&A	24	↑42% 34	↑18% 40	955	↓44% 532	↓33% 358
PE	96	↓10% 86	↑22% 105	1,313	↑125% 2,950	↓64% 1,065
Grand total	120	120	↑21% 145	2,268	↑54% 3,482	↓59% 1,423

Source: Grant Thornton Bharat

M&A STRENGTHENED Top five M&A and PE deals accounted for 57 per cent of total deal value, reflecting a high degree of concentration in a handful of large transactions despite overall moderate deal sizes. The largest deal of the quarter was Hindustan Unilever Ltd's acquisition of a 49 per cent stake in Zwyie Ventures Pvt Ltd for \$90 million. With 40 deals valued at \$358 million, M&A activity strengthened in volume, driven primarily by domestic transactions, with a pick-up

in cross-border deal count. However, average deal sizes contracted, signalling a continued focus on consolidation-led and selective acquisitions rather than scale-driven investments. M&A activity remained concentrated in food processing, personal care and FMCG, with a clear focus on portfolio expansion, premiumisation and capability building. "With 105 deals valuing \$1.1 billion, private equity and venture capital activity remained resilient..." it added.

Suzlon in initial RE pact with Korean firm GSE&C

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Suzlon Energy and Korean firm GS E&C exchanged initial pact for a partnership in India's renewable energy business and the optimisation of related solutions.

The MoU was exchanged during the India-Korea Business Forum in the presence of Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and his Korean counterpart Yeo Han-koo. A document showed the partnership will focus on mutual cooperation in developing renewable energy projects and optimising related solutions (total project size: approximately KRW 80 billion; specific investment amount to be determined; 300-odd direct and indirect jobs expected).

GS E&C is engaged in engineering and construction.

Philips' Personal Health doubles down on Gen Z, digital traction

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

Philips personal health arm is sharpening its India strategy as it looks to turn the market into one of its top growth engines. Deeptha Khanna, Executive Vice-President and Chief Business Leader, Personal Health, and a member of the Royal Philips Executive Committee, said India is already among the company's top-10 growth drivers and is poised to break into the top-five, backed by strong momentum over the past few years. The company is leaning heavily into a Gen Z-focused, digital-first playbook, reflecting a broader shift in

consumer behaviour. "We've reshaped our strategy to stay relevant with younger consumers," Khanna said, pointing to sharper portfolio curation, influencer-led marketing, and deeper investments in e-commerce and quick commerce. These channels now account for nearly 40 per cent of Philips' India sales, as of 2025. Grooming and beauty continue to anchor the business, with Philips holding a dominant position in categories such as shaving and trimming. As of 2025, Philips commands a leading market position in male grooming, with an estimated 40-50 per cent share. The company had a strong and growing presence in beauty portfolio last year



Deeptha Khanna, Executive Vice-President and Chief Business Leader, Personal Health

as well, added Khanna. These segments are expected to remain growth drivers, supported by favourable demographics and rising aspirations around

personal care. At the same time, the company is expanding its play in adjacent categories. Mother and child care is emerging as a strong opportunity, driven by India's large birth cohort and increasing focus on hygiene and safety. Oral healthcare, while still nascent, is being positioned as a long-term bet, with the company investing in consumer education to drive adoption.

LOCALISED NEEDS A key pillar of Philips' India strategy is innovation, particularly around localised needs. From premium, AI-enabled grooming devices to sterilisation products tailored for Indian parents, the company is focusing on building a portfolio that

spans price points while addressing specific consumer behaviours. India is also playing a larger role in Philips' global innovation ecosystem, especially in software and product development. With a growing base of engineering talent and increasing local manufacturing, the market is not just about consumption but also about contributing to global capabilities, with about 40 per cent of localised manufacturing of what's sold in India. As consumer preferences shift towards proactive wellness and technology-led solutions, Philips is betting that its digital reach, and category expansion will help sustain above-market growth in India.

JSW, Posco sign pact for 6 mtpa plant

Our Bureau
Mumbai

JSW Steel and South Korea's Posco have signed a JV agreement to set up a 6 mtpa greenfield steel plant in Odisha. In 2024, both companies signed MoU and an agreement was signed last year. This has now been fortified with the signing of the joint venture agreement. The proposed integrated steel project will comprise steelmaking, hot rolling, and cold rolling/coating processes. The land has already been secured. Once commissioned by 2031, the plant will be capable of manufacturing high-grade flat steel products for automotive and

other applications. Leveraging on Posco's technological expertise, the JV's portfolio will complement that of JSW and provide new product opportunities in India. **INDIA ACCESS** The project gives Posco access to India's high growth market. The joint venture aims to leverage the integration with Posco's 1.8 mtpa downstream unit in Pune to drive significant synergies. The completion of the transaction is subject to receipt of regulatory approvals. Jayant Acharya, Joint Managing Director & CEO, JSW Steel said the partnership will ensure alignment of the company's vision and

commitment, while leveraging Posco's technological expertise and JSW's strengths in project execution and cost leadership. Lee Hee-geun, President, Posco, said the joint venture will make a meaningful contribution not only to future value creation but also to the industrial development and economic growth of both nations.

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QUICKLY.

Govt buys back ₹12,687 cr in RBI G-sec auction

Mumbai: The government bought back government securities (G-secs) worth ₹12,686.974 crore from the switch auction conducted by the Reserve Bank of India on Monday, and issued bonds worth ₹13,311.383 crore. Two securities repurchased by the government were part of the scheduled bonds set to mature later this financial year. These included ₹2,316 crore of 5.74 per cent GS 2026, and ₹1,000 crore of 8.24 per cent GS 2027. The government repurchased securities worth ₹3,000 crore of 6.79 per cent GS 2027, ₹1,640.594 crore of 8.60 per cent GS 2028, ₹3,000 crore of 7.59 per cent GS 2029, and ₹1,730.380 crore of 7.10 per cent GS 2029, it said.

States' capex growth to slow down to 8-10% in FY27

Mumbai: States' capital expenditure growth is likely to slow down to 8-10 per cent in FY27 from 17 per cent in FY26, a report said on Monday. The moderation will primarily result from tighter fiscal headroom due to rising revenue expenditure commitments and a moderation in revenue growth, Careedge Ratings said.

Ceasefire talks under strain after US seizes Iranian cargo ship

Reuters
Washington/Cairo

Concerns grew on Monday that the ceasefire between the US and Iran might not hold after the US said it had seized an Iranian cargo ship that tried to run its blockade and Iran vowed to retaliate. Efforts to build a more lasting peace in the region likewise appeared to be on shaky ground, as Iran said it would not participate in a second round of negotiations that the US had hoped to kick off before the ceasefire expires on Tuesday. The US has maintained a blockade of Iranian ports, while Iran has lifted and then reimposed its own blockade on marine traffic passing through the Strait of Hormuz. The US military said Sunday it fired on an Iranian-

In touch with Iran for safe passage of ships, says MEA

SUPPLY ADEQUATE. There is no shortage of fuel at bunks, says Petroleum Ministry

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Emphasising that high priority is accorded to the welfare of Indian seafarers, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Monday that it is in touch with Iranian authorities for safe passage of Indian vessels after last week's firing incident in the Strait of Hormuz (SoH).

On Saturday (April 18), two Indian vessels, VLCC *Sammar Herald* and bulk carrier *Jag Arnav*, reported a firing incident while transiting the SoH, following which they returned to the Persian Gulf.

Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson for the MEA, said: "We continue to be in touch with the Iranian authorities for the safety of our ships, for the safe exit through the Strait of Hormuz".

Around three Indian and 14 foreign flagged vessels are in west Persian Gulf awaiting safe transit through the SoH. These include four LPG carriers, three LNG vessels and 10 crude oil tankers.

On Saturday's firing incident,



TAKING STOCK. Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson, Ministry of External Affairs, during an inter-ministerial briefing on the recent developments in West Asia, in New Delhi on Monday

Jaiswal said: "When this matter was reported to us, we took it up very strongly. We called in the Iranian Ambassador. He had a meeting with the Foreign Secretary. Foreign Secretary conveyed our deep concerns on this incident and also reiterated the point that we have been making, that we attach very high importance to the safety and security of our mariners of commercial shipping, and that there should (get) unimpeded transit through the SoH. So, these points were put forth, and the ambassador was told that these may be conveyed to authorities back home."

So far, nine Indian flagged ships have safely crossed the SoH and reached India. One vessel is yet to reach and will happen soon, he added. The Shipping Ministry said that it is in "close and continuous communication" with the crew and owners of *Sammar Herald* and *Jag Arnav*. The Ministry is closely monitoring the situation, and safety and security of Indian seafarers is the government's top priority.

OIL SUPPLIES Meanwhile, the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas (MoPNG) said that India has sufficient supplies of crude

oil. Besides, there is no shortage of petrol and diesel at retail fuel bunks. Despite the ongoing geopolitical situation in West Asia, the government has ensured 100 per cent supply to domestic LPG, domestic PNG and CNG (Transport). Besides, total commercial LPG allocation has been increased to about 70 per cent of pre-crisis levels, including 10 per cent reform-linked allocation.

Since March 23, more than 18.45 lakh 5-kg Free Trade LPG cylinders have been sold. During the last 5 days, on an average more than 7000 tonnes per day of commercial LPG has been sold. Around 1.75 lakh tonnes of commercial LPG have been sold since March 14.

The average auto LPG sale by PSU OMCs in the last one week is around 350 tonnes per day against the average of 177 TPD during February 2026.

Auto LPG sales were observed to have shifted from private to PSU OMCs. To meet the rising demand, the sale of auto LPG by the PSU OMCs has been increased.

Core sector shrinks 0.4% in March due to supply chain issues

Our Bureau
New Delhi

With disruptions in the supply chain, growth of eight core infrastructure industries shrank 0.4 per cent in March, data from Commerce & Industry Ministry showed.

This is the first contraction in five months and the weakest performance of the core sector in nearly two years. The growth rate was 2.8 per cent in February.

"The production of fertilizers, crude oil, coal and electricity recorded negative growth in March," a statement by Commerce & Industry Ministry said. However, steel and natural gas

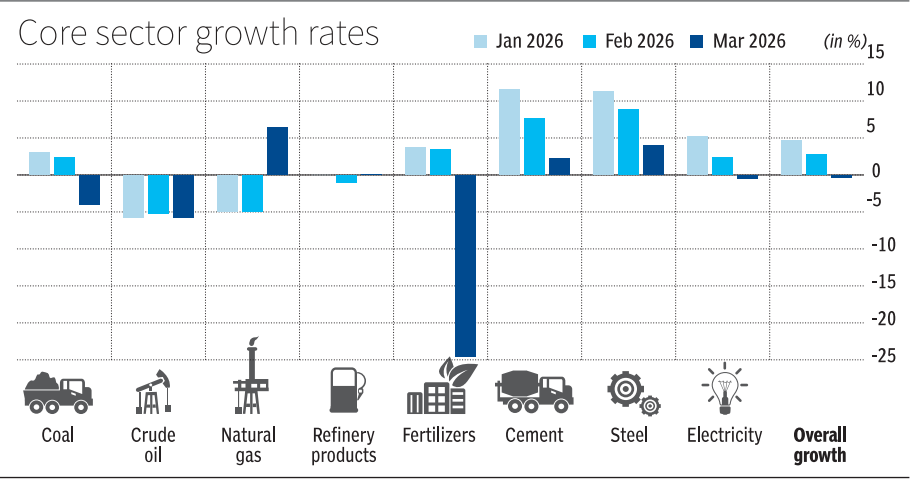
showed some upward movement. These eight sectors contribute 40 per cent in overall industrial growth number.

Fertilizers recorded a major dip where output plunged 24.6 per cent in March. Fertilizer manufacturing faces further headwinds from the West Asia crisis, given the region's role as a dominant supplier of the industry's raw materials.

Coal production declined 4 per cent while crude oil fell 5.7 per cent, extending a prolonged contraction in domestic hydrocarbon production. Electricity generation also slipped 0.5 per cent suggesting softer power demand or favourable weather.

"While an adverse base weighed on electricity generation, a shortage of inputs amidst the West Asia crisis curtailed the fertilizer output," said Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist with ICRA. The growth in steel and cement output also weakened in March relative to February, suggesting that construction activity slowed in the month. Natural gas output expanded by 6.4 per cent in March, the fastest pace in 22 months, as domestic players ramped up production, amidst fall in imports from West Asia.

Given these trends, ICRA expects the IIP growth to slow to 1-2 per cent in March as against 5.2 per cent in February," Nayar said.



Disruptions at 3 Russian ports may impact India's refinery ops

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Continued disruptions at three top Russian crude oil loading ports on the Baltic and Black sea due to Ukrainian drone strikes last month is expected to alter supplies to India, which can have serious repercussions for the world's fourth largest refiner.

According to the International Energy Agency's (IEA) April 2026 oil market report, following earlier strikes on the Black Sea port of Novorossiysk, Ukrainian drones targeted the Baltic ports of Ust-Luga and Primorsk during the week of March 23.

Together, the three ports accounted for around 68 per cent of seaborne oil exports in 2025 shipped from Russian ports, comprising 72 per cent crude and 28 per cent products.

"Beyond Russia's export



UNDER ATTACK. A file photo of Russia's Baltic port of Ust-Luga after a Ukrainian attack

logistics, 80 per cent of India's Russian crude imports in 2025 originated from Primorsk, Ust-Luga and Novorossiysk. Indian total crude imports fell by 760,000 b/d m-o-m in March (2026), and any prolonged disruption to Russian port availability could significantly affect Indian refining operations in the coming weeks," the IEA anticipated.

STORAGE TANKS HIT At Primorsk, around 8 of 18 crude storage tanks were

destroyed, while satellite imagery showed fires and heavy smoke at Ust-Luga, affecting crude oil tanks and potentially the 160,000 barrels per day (b/d) crude splitter, it said.

The attacks halted Primorsk exports for several days, while Ust-Luga remained offline for more than a week. Loadings at Primorsk resumed two days after the attacks and averaged 1.4 million b/d (mb/d) in the week of 6 April while Ust-Luga

loadings remained 300,000 b/d below 2025 levels, it added.

"There is no pipeline connection between the two Baltic ports, requiring upstream scheduling adjustments. While re-routing crude to the Black Sea is technically feasible, only 23 per cent of volumes exported last month were Russian crude, from Sheskhari, with the remainder originating from Kazakhstan and loaded from the CPC terminal," IEA pointed out.

During March, importing countries received 4.4 mb/d of Russian crude oil, with India unloading 2 mb/d and China 1.8 mb/d. Indian crude imports rose by 930,000 b/d m-o-m after the US waived restrictions on purchases for cargoes loaded before March 5.

An estimated 22 million barrels of Russian oil on water came onshore in India in March, and 14 million bar-

rels in China, wiping out the volumes at sea that had built up since October 2025. In March, 12 Indian refineries processed Russian crude, compared with seven in February 2026, IEA added.

Reliance, Essar top bidders for CBM blocks

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Reliance Industries Ltd and Essar Group have emerged as top bidders for the 16 coal-bed methane (CBM) blocks offered across two consecutive bidding rounds, according to a list of bidders released by the Directorate General of Hydrocarbons.

State-owned Oil India Ltd bid for three blocks while India's largest oil and gas producer, ONGC stayed away.

The government offered three areas for exploration and production of natural gas that is trapped within coal seams underground, in the Special CBM Bid Round 2025, and another 13 blocks in the 2026 bidding round. Bids for the two rounds closed on March 5.

The gas produced, called CBM or coal seam gas, is used as a cleaner-burning fuel for power generation, heating, and industrial use. It can also be turned into CNG to run automobiles and piped to household kitchens for cooking. It generally produces fewer emissions than coal when burned.

Blocks offered in the 2025 and 2026 Special CBM bid rounds fall in Category II and III basins, where entities offering the most work programme (drilling most wells) are awarded the areas.

Reliance bid for three out of the 13 blocks offered in Special CBM Bid Round 2026 while Essar Oil and Gas Exploration and Production Ltd (EOGEPL) bid for three



blocks of 2026 round and two of the three blocks offered in 2025 round.

One block in the 2025 round and seven of 2026 round did not attract any bids, according to DGH.

Four of the six blocks of 2026 round that got bids, were single bids. The two blocks of 2025 round got multiple bids.

CHANDIGARH & ODISHA Reliance was the sole bidder for two blocks in Chhattisgarh and Odisha (SR-ONHP (CBM)-2026/4 block in Mand-Raigarh coal field in Chhattisgarh and SR-ONHP (CBM)-2026/5 block in IB Valley coal field in Odisha. It was in direct contest with EOGEPL for the PG-ONHP (CBM)-2026/5 block in Godavari Valley coal field in Telangana.

EOGEPL was the sole bidder for PG-ONHP (CBM)-2026/3 block in Godavari Valley coal field in Telangana while state-owned Oil India Ltd was the only bidder for SR-ONHP (CBM)-2026/1 CBM block of Singrauli coalfield in Madhya Pradesh. OIL and EOGEPL were locked for another block in the Singrauli coalfield of Madhya Pradesh.

MCA proposes revamp of filing framework, seeks suggestions

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

To ease compliance, the Corporate Affairs Ministry has proposed overhauling the filing framework for corporates. The proposal includes the consolidation of forms, transition to a data-centric architecture, expansion of straight through processing (STP), and the adoption of an interaction-based, pre-filled filing interface (MCA21 Version 3).

STRATEGIC POINT

Explaining the need for change, the Ministry said in a consultation paper that India now stands at a defining strategic inflection point.

The next phase of reform offers an opportunity to set new international benchmarks in digital corporate governance, building a framework that the world looks to as a model of transparency, efficiency, and regulatory excellence. "This effort is anchored in the national vision of Viksit Bharat@2047, wherein India's regulatory architecture must be fully calibrated to support a \$30 trillion economy," it said.

The Ministry has listed five objectives for multi-city stakeholder consultations to be undertaken through the Indian Institute of Corporate Affairs (IICA). The first objective is to map high-impact reform opportunities across all stages of the cor-

PROPOSALS Consolidation of forms; transition to a data-centric architecture; expansion of straight through processing; and adoption of an interaction-based, pre-filled filing interface

porate lifecycle, i.e., from incorporation to exit. The second objective is to harness practitioner expertise to elevate, strengthen, and future-proof compliance workflows.

The third objective is to unlock automation potential through intelligent system integration, pre-filing, and reuse of registry data. The fourth aims to provide advanced technology-driven compliance by transitioning to a globally benchmarked digital architecture. The fifth one is to ensure inclusive, evidence-based reform that reflects the lived experience of businesses, professionals, and regulators.

The consultation paper sets three questions, a combination of multiple-choice and detailed response. One question asks for the single most important goal of rationalising the MCA filing architecture. Options include reduction in the total number of forms to lower compliance burden, consolidation of forms with overlapping data fields and similar stat-

utory purpose, transition to a data-centric architecture (file once, use everywhere), expansion of STP to enable fully automated, approval-free processing for standard filings, adoption of a modular filing model (core form with conditional annexures), risk-based differentiation — separating high-risk filings from low-risk disclosures, threshold-based compliance calibration (MSME vs large; listed vs unlisted) or integration of MCA data with GSTN, CBDT, SEBI, RBI — eliminating duplicate cross-regulatory reporting.

VARIOUS CHOICES

Another question seeks criteria for guiding decisions on form consolidation or merger. Choices include similarity in statutory purpose, data fields, or triggering event, potential for auto-population or reuse of registry data, preservation of third-party rights (creditors, investors, depositors), evidentiary value of the filing in legal or adjudicatory proceedings, requirement of professional certification or government approval (RoC/RD/Central Govt), impact on regulatory supervision and early-risk detection, risk of misuse, suppression, or delayed reporting if merged, interoperability with SEBI, RBI, GSTN, or other regulatory frameworks and international benchmarking against comparable registries (UK Companies House, Singapore ACRA, etc.).

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NOTICE
Unitholders are hereby informed about the declaration of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal for below mentioned schemes under Payout/Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal option (IDCW-Payout/Reinvestment) of the following schemes. The record date for the same is 23 April, 2026.

Schemes - Plan Name	Gross income distribution cum capital withdrawal amount per unit (Rs.) **	Face value per unit (₹)	NAV (₹) as on 17 Apr, 26
Tata Banking & Financial Services Fund - Direct Plan	1.59	10.00	51.4054
Tata Banking & Financial Services Fund - Regular Plan	1.59	10.00	40.1663
Tata Ethical Fund - Direct Plan	5.85	10.00	230.4364
Tata Ethical Fund - Regular Plan	5.85	10.00	148.4797
Tata India Consumer Fund - Direct Plan	1.56	10.00	50.1873
Tata India Consumer Fund - Regular Plan	1.56	10.00	39.8453
Tata Large & Mid Cap Fund - Direct Plan	6.14	10.00	108.5334
Tata Large & Mid Cap Fund - Regular Plan	6.14	10.00	77.6709
Tata Large Cap Fund - Direct Plan	8.64	10.00	131.7188
Tata Large Cap Fund - Regular Plan	8.64	10.00	109.2233
Tata Mid Cap Fund - Direct Plan	4.83	10.00	167.8693
Tata Mid Cap Fund - Regular Plan	4.83	10.00	122.3450
Tata Resources & Energy Fund - Direct Plan	1.74	10.00	57.4741
Tata Resources & Energy Fund - Regular Plan	1.74	10.00	44.2881

Pursuant to payment of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal, the NAV of the scheme would fall to the extent of the payout & statutory levy (if applicable).
Unitholders kindly note that amounts are distributed out of investors capital (i.e., Equalisation Reserve), which is part of sale price of the unit that represents realized gains.
** Payment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to Tax deducted at source (TDS) at applicable rates and other statutory levies if any. Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to availability & adequacy of distributable surplus on the record date.
All unitholders holding units under the above-mentioned option of the scheme as at close of business hours, on the record date shall be eligible for Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal.
Considering the volatile nature of markets, the Trustees reserves the right to restrict the quantum of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal upto the per unit distributable surplus available on the record date in case of fall in the market.
Applicable for units held in non-demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders whose names appear in the Register of Unitholders under the Payout/Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in our records.
Applicable for units held in demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders/Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories under the Payout/Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in Depository Participant(s) records.
Mutual Fund Investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

Snooping around

CCTVs with Chinese spyware must be weeded out

A recent report in this newspaper about hostile entities compromising Indian closed circuit TV networks has evoked considerable unease. These technologies seek to provide ‘security’, but often double up as spyware. Notably, reports indicate that Pakistan’s Inter-Services Intelligence recently accessed live visual feeds and information from key defence and police sites over a period of three months across Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan and Jammu and Kashmir via devices linked to EseeCloud — a Chinese software platform commonly used in surveillance equipment.



The larger truth is that India’s national security and intelligence apparatus relies too much on China for technology. Over the last few years, India has been progressively tightening regulations on the use of foreign-made CCTV equipment. Effective April 1 this year, rules prohibiting the sale of CCTVs that fail to meet prescribed testing norms kicked in. Moving from loose governance to mandating ‘Essential Requirements’ for CCTV equipment was indeed long overdue. Currently, a vast majority of CCTVs sold, especially the cameras that come as part of the package, are sourced from China. Indian companies claiming increased market share remain tethered to Chinese supply chains for essential parts. The new norms, overseen by the Standardised Testing and Quality Certification (STQC) Directorate, require equipment clearance — for software, firmware and hardware. The testing in this regard will be done at STQC centres or labs accredited by the Ministry of Electronics & IT (Meity). While this regulatory framework is a good first step, the most rigorous assessments could miss miniscule hardware implants. For instance, nearly a decade ago, intelligence authorities in the US purportedly discovered grain-sized hardware in a technology major’s servers, used to clandestinely transmit information to China.

In the corporate sector, it is imperative that companies ensure their corporate networks are independent of, or if not, at least secured from, their security systems even if the two are integrated. Given that security infrastructure depends heavily on imported components, a ‘trojan horse’ — particularly in vendor systems servicing government or defence establishments — that infiltrates networks could prove disastrous. Even if the CCTV equipment itself is secure, the involvement of third-party service providers introduces risks beyond the government’s purview. For example, the security of recordings uploaded to the cloud is contingent upon the provider’s systems. Similarly, if integration service providers — who assemble products using components from various specialists — remain lax about security, infiltration becomes child’s play.

For now, the CCTV policy seems a solo move in a sea of other dependencies. India needs to transition from assembling units to designing and manufacturing them locally. An indigenous semiconductor ecosystem and CCTV sector is a must. A roadmap of say three years, should be drawn up to this end.

POCKET



C RANGARAJAN
NR BHANUMURTHY

The world is entering an era of ‘Might is Right’. It has always been so but with the two recent wars — Russia-Ukraine and US, Israel-Iran — this has become pronounced.

Even if there is some justification, relentless attacking of another country through air strikes is a violation of the principle with which the international order was built up after World War II. In this new situation, in a world interconnected through trade, not only the nations directly involved but also other nations suffer. The world trade is shrinking. Interdependence has become a liability.

Earlier, unilateral imposition of high tariffs by US resulted in the weaponisation of tariffs. Tariffs were used to achieve non-economic objectives. Developing economies were allowed to levy tariffs on certain commodities because of the time needed to catch up with developed countries.

If this is to be reconsidered, there is a forum and method to do it. Unilateral actions on tariffs can only disrupt world trade. How should developing countries react to the emerging situation of wars and tariffs? What can be done to reduce their adverse impact?

REVERSAL OF TRADE THEORY
The economic impact of the two wars has been severe. They have knocked out the very basis of international trade, the world order and its governance. International trade theory suggests that if there is free trade among countries, each country will produce that commodity in which it has a comparative advantage. The net result will be that the world will be a least-cost economy with welfare gains.

Of course there are certain caveats. When WTO was being set up, experts recognised that there is a need to provide certain concessions to developing countries as mentioned earlier. Benefits of international trade are also built on the premise that there are no impediments in the transport of goods.

Unfortunately, we see a breakdown of all these assumptions in the current situation. There is a blockade of Strait of Hormuz by both US and Iran. India depends on Gulf countries for crude oil to a large extent. Nearly half of India’s oil imports are from Gulf countries. India’s dependence on Gulf countries for gas is even greater. If there is no free passage through the Strait, we face an extremely difficult situation.

Overall availability of crude oil gets reduced and prices shoot up. Both US and Iran are ignoring the code of conduct laid down by maritime laws. Strait of Hormuz is not Suez Canal



REUTERS

How two wars have upended the global order

UNCERTAIN FUTURE. Collapse of the rules based global trading framework will lead to a high-cost economic system. Creating ample buffer stocks of fuel and fertilizer is the way out

which was artificially constructed and where toll fee is permissible. Strait of Hormuz is a natural sea way. A modest toll fee may be permissible to take care of the maintenance of the sea way but not a heavy toll.

SUPPLY DISRUPTIONS AND ALTERNATIVES
Supply disruptions affect the production processes. The supply chain linking many countries is an integral part of the production system now world over. With the Strait of Hormuz being restricted and breaking the supply chain, it has caused heavy risks on both growth and inflation across the countries.

What could have been done by India or any other country caught in this mess? First, particularly in the case of critical inputs, we should avoid dependence on other countries. This is not always possible. In the case of crude oil, it is nature’s gift.

One thing we can do is not to rely on one group of countries particularly geographically aligned, but diversify the sourcing. India has moved in that direction. There are almost 41 countries

For an import dependent nation like India, geographical diversification of sourcing, building strategic reserves of fuel and pushing the renewable energy agenda are the viable options

from which India is importing. In fact, India’s attempt to import from Russia also came under special attack earlier with US levying 25 per cent tax on imports from countries that had traded with Russia.

Second, if import is unavoidable can we hold an inventory lasting for several months? Data indicate that this has also been done, although not at the scale as suggested by International Energy Agency (IEA), which suggest Strategic Petroleum Reserve (SPR) covering 90 days of domestic consumption. But this has a high cost. Expensive storage facilities will also have to be put up. One has to strike a balance here. We can look at how Japan has done, which has reserves that can cover domestic consumption for more than 200 days.

Another way to do is to look at the option of having forward commercial storage agreements with source companies that will reduce the cost.

Third, India and other countries must look at alternative sources of energy. Use of coal was discouraged because of environmental considerations. Solar energy is a good option. Much has been done in recent years with its share in total installed power generation capacity increasing to about 25 per cent. But more should be done. On a mission mode expansion in the area must be undertaken.

The other alternative is nuclear energy. India has made progress in this area also. France is one major country where, based on some estimates, nuclear energy meets nearly 70 per cent of energy requirements with 57 nuclear

reactors in place. However, safety concerns related to nuclear energy cannot be brushed aside. Experts need to come together and provide a plan of action. These, however, are all medium-term objectives.

While a number of initiatives can be undertaken to take care of the present situation, one must take note that the world is moving towards a sub-optimal situation. We will have to live in a costlier system. In the emerging world of dominance of ‘might’, will defence need more attention? Will ‘guns’ take a lead over ‘butter’ in the allocation of resources?

Emerging economies like India need to create buffers for essential commodities to mitigate the exogenous shocks. Some of the essential inputs that we may have to focus could be food, fuel (including gas), fertilizer, and on the resources side, it is foreign exchange reserves and fiscal space. India has sufficient food and forex reserves. Forex reserves do not help always us in the present case when, supply is disrupted. With prudent fiscal management, India has created a fiscal space to mitigate the risks. Fiscal prudence must continue to remain a major focus of the government.

With the changing world situation, the medium-term strategy must be to create buffers for fuel and fertilizers or any other commodity, which is critically important. We should also work towards an improved world environment of cooperation rather than confrontation.

Rangarajan is Chairman and Bhanumurthy is Director of Madras School of Economics, Chennai

A ratings tweak that could enhance bank credit

RBI’s proposal to alter rating-risk mapping can free up credit to the MSME sector

Venkataraman S

In late 2025, as part of a draft paper put out for public comments, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) proposed certain modified norms for scheduled commercial banks, with regard to computation of capital charge for credit risk. If implemented, these guidelines can hugely impact the Indian banking sector as well as the loan-seeking corporate sector.

Currently, RBI requires Indian banks to keep a minimum level of capital according to borrowers’ credit ratings by agencies like Crisil, ICRA , CARE etc. Such a capital charge follows the globally recognized regulatory standards developed by the Bank of International Settlements (BIS) — generally referred to as Basel Norms.

Maintaining minimum capital according to Risk Weighted Assets (RWA), in order to moderate the impact of credit risk is a central tenet of Basel norms, although the latter’s scope also includes other aspects. RBI’s recent proposal becomes significant in this

context. Credit rating agencies denote credit risk in ordered risk categories such as AAA, AA, A, BBB, BB, B etc., wherein borrowers rated BB or lower, are generally considered to ingrain high risk. The current RBI norms for computing RWA apply graded weights ranging from 20-80 per cent from AAA to A, 100 per cent to BBB, and from 150 per cent upwards to credits rated BB category or lower.

For example, if a bank lends ₹100 to a company rated BB, applying current RWA norms, it is considered as effectively having lent ₹150; whereas if it lends the same amount to a AAA borrower, it is considered effectively as having lent only ₹20; and as ₹100 itself, if the entity is rated in the BBB category. Accordingly, the capital banks maintain have to be higher or lower.

Given this RWA approach, banks have to strategically choose how much and to whom they lend to. It has a direct implication on banks’ ability to grow their loan book. By implication, this also impacts the credit availability for companies — especially for those that



RBI PROPOSAL. A game changer

fall in perceived higher risk categories, such as SMEs and MSMEs.

WHAT’S THE BIG CHANGE?
RBI’s proposal effectively shifts the rating-risk mapping by one step. That is, instead of 100 per cent risk weight being applied at the BBB category, it may now apply only at the BB category. The import of this single step-change however is staggering. One, this can release a huge amount of money for lending, as banks’ capital charge effectively eases.

An Crisil estimate pegs this extra amount of the order of about ₹70,000 crore. Also, about 25-30 per cent of all rated companies fall in the BB category,

and they can all benefit from this change. With this move, RBI has prompted and also effectively enabled banks to now approach the SME segment with a lot more intent, and much less stigma.

But it also needs to be accompanied by appropriately stronger credit appraisal and monitoring banks, to ensure prudent growth. The impetus for growth that this step affords to the important SME/MSME sector can be tremendous. Finally, the proposed norms, if implemented, will bring RBI’s RWA norms to closer alignment with the Basel-III norms, the current norms being more conservative.

RBI’s consultative paper has more to it beyond the change in RWA. This includes a mapping of ratings to Probability of Default (PD), a much-needed measure to enhance the quality of credit ratings. Nevertheless, this step change in the RWA dispensation can be a game-changer for Indian banking and SMEs.

The writer is Associate Dean and Associate Professor, IIM Kozhikode

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Fertilizer crisis

This refers to ‘West Asia crisis and fertilizer management’, (April 20). The intensifying geopolitical turbulence across West Asia has precipitated a structural dislocation in global fertilizer supply chains, acutely exposing India’s import dependence. Disruptions in natural gas availability — an indispensable feedstock for nitrogenous fertilizers — have escalated production costs and constrained supply, transmitting inflationary pressures onto an already distressed agrarian economy. This exogenous shock calls for diversification of sourcing geographies, augmentation of domestic manufacturing capacity, and incentivisation of bio-fertilizers

and sustainable agronomic practices.

Furthermore, rationalising the subsidy regime and instituting strategic reserves, coupled with resilient bilateral procurement arrangements, are imperative to mitigate volatility and fortify long-term agricultural security.

N Sadhasiva Reddy
Bengaluru

Bill fiasco

Apropos ‘Ahead of polls, DMK unveils ‘Chennai Super 6’ manifesto’ (April 20). This manifesto stands apart from rival party pledges by offering a city-specific vision rather than only State-wide welfare promises. While AIADMK, BJP, and TVK

Parliamentary seats did not cut ice with States as it was not written into the Bill. But the Opposition too must understand the need to to revise Parliament seats given the rise in population. On women’s reservation, the government seeking political mileage by pushing the Opposition in a corner also must not be ignored.

RV Baskaran
Pune

Unique DMK manifesto

Apropos ‘Ahead of polls, DMK unveils ‘Chennai Super 6’ manifesto’ (April 20). This manifesto stands apart from rival party pledges by offering a city-specific vision rather than only State-wide welfare promises. While AIADMK, BJP, and TVK

emphasize subsidies and cash transfers, DMK also addresses Chennai’s urban needs — mini-buses, Metro completion by 2028, AI-enabled traffic systems, stormwater drain upgrades, and RO-purified water and surprisingly ‘stray dog menace’. It also blends technology and culture, promising AI hubs, gaming and animation centres, and a world-class cultural facility under the “Dravidian Model 2.0.” This dual strategy positions DMK as both a welfare provider and moderniser, distinguishing its manifesto from competitors who remain largely welfare-centric without a comparable urban development plan.

O Prasada Rao
Hyderabad

Systemic brutality

This refers to ‘The tragic reality of police brutality’ (April 20). The death sentence handed to nine policemen for the heinous torture and eventual death of a father-son duo in Tamil Nadu’s Sattankulam draws attention to the deep-rooted, systematic fault-lines in the country’s police force. This incident would have been forgotten but for the huge public outcry which sparked an enquiry and the subsequent court prosecution. Unless fundamental Police reforms are implemented, beginning with entry-level candidate screening, and it is protected from external pressure, the episode is unlikely to be the last of its kind.

Kamal Laddha
Bengaluru

QUICKLY.

Aavas Financiers appoints Manu Yeshpal as CEO



Mumbai: Aavas Financiers Ltd on Monday announced the appointment of Manu Yeshpal Singh as its new Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer, effective April 21, subject to the approval of RBI and shareholders. The Jaipur-based affordable housing finance company's stock rose 1.28 per cent to ₹1,365.20 on the NSE. **OUR BUREAU**

IIFL credit fund raises ₹500 crore

New Delhi: Investment firm IIFL Capital Services Ltd announced the first closure of IIFL Capital Credit Opportunities Fund, securing capital commitments of over ₹500 crore. This has been achieved in a short span of time, underscoring strong demand from HNIs and family offices seeking differentiated exposure. **PTI**

Reserve Bank partially rolls back April 1 forex market measures

MORE CLARITY. The April 1 directive was aimed at curbing speculation and arbitrage in foreign exchange market

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Monday decided to partially roll back its measures that prevented Authorised Dealers (ADs) from offering foreign exchange derivative contract involving the Indian rupee. This comes in the wake of hedging becoming difficult and dollar liquidity tightening.

RBI said ADs cannot undertake any foreign exchange derivative contract involving INR (Indian Rupee) with their related parties except for cancellation and rollover of existing contracts, and transactions undertaken with non-related non-resident users on a back-to-back basis.

The April 1 RBI directive, which was aimed at curbing speculation and arbitrage in foreign exchange market, disallowed ADs to offer non-



FURTHER CURBS. Authorised dealers cannot undertake any foreign exchange derivative contract involving the rupee with their related parties, said the central bank

deliverable derivative contracts involving INR to resident or non-resident users. Further, they could not permit a user to rebook any foreign exchange derivative contract involving INR, whether deliverable or non-deliverable, which is cancelled.

Dipti Deodhar, CEO, Mecklavi Financial Services, observed that the original action was intended to curb the speculation and effectively

break the momentum of rupee depreciation on account of speculative positions.

She said this measure had unintentional consequences like hedging becoming difficult, liquidity drying up and at some psychological level it led to panic.

“So, as a solution, RBI allowed NDF (non-deliverable forward) access again (a key liquidity restoration step) and removed rebooking restriction (restores flexibil-

ity),” opined Deodhar. However it has still not allowed ADs entering into fx derivative (involving INR) with related parties except for original contracts being cancelled and rebooked - this will ensure no round tripping or artificial volume creation.

“While this move is not particularly rupee positive or something that can cause rupee appreciation, it certainly stabilises the rupee outlook with improved liquidity and reduced offshore dominance. We can read this as extreme downside risk being managed more smoothly now,” she said.

SPECULATIVE ACTIVITY
V Rama Chandra Reddy, Head - Treasury, Karur Vysya Bank, noted that while the earlier RBI measures were aimed at curbing speculative activity, their combined impact tightened liquidity and affected normal

market functioning. “The rollback helps restore flexibility, improve price discovery and bring stability back to the onshore FX market. For the rupee, the impact is largely neutral as it supports liquidity without encouraging excessive speculation,” he said.

Abhishek Goenka, Founder and CEO, IFA Global, said the earlier restriction on cancellation and rebooking against same underlying exposure had created difficulties for those with genuine reasons, for instance, a delay in payment/receipt. “It would have also been operationally difficult for banks to track and establish whether the same underlying was being used to rebook. They would have had to rely on undertaking from clients,” he said. Goenka observed that it was a view in the market that such moves could be perceived as regressive.

Apple withholds data in India antitrust case; CCI sets final hearing for May 21

Reuters
New Delhi



Apple has not submitted data sought by India's antitrust body after an investigation found the US firm abused its dominant position in the iPhone apps market, prompting the watchdog to fast-track a decision on penalties to a final hearing next month, an order shows.

The Competition Commission of India (CCI) said in an April 8 order that Apple has not submitted details of its financials and its views on the investigation since October 2024, and instead cited a separate case pending in the Delhi High Court where the company has challenged India's entire antitrust penalty law. The CCI typically requires financial information from companies to calculate penalties when they are found to have contravened the law.

Apple, which denies any wrongdoing in the case, has said it fears it could be fined up to \$38 billion if the watchdog uses its global turnover to calculate penalties in the case.

Apple has “been afforded adequate opportunities to file” its objections or suggestions to the investigation report and has also “not sub-

mitted the requisite financial information,” said the CCI order, which is not public but was reviewed by *Reuters*.

Apple and the CCI did not respond to *Reuters* queries. The Indian case is among the many Apple faces around the globe for alleged antitrust breaches. India is a key market for Apple where its iPhones have an 9 per cent market share, compared to just 4 per cent two years ago, Counterpoint Research says.

FINAL HEARING DATE

Although the CCI has given Apple two more weeks to file its responses, it has for the first time fixed a final hearing date of May 21. Lawyers said the setting of a final hearing date signals the watchdog is hardening its stance. “Apple has the opportunity right now to submit its financials supported by an auditor's certificate and then argue on quantum of penalty during the hearing based on these financials,” said Gautam Shahi, an antitrust partner at Dua Associates.

HDFC Bank's Q4 implies attractive valuation

Nishanth Gopalakrishnan
bl, research bureau



CAUTIOUS GROWTH. Going into FY27, loan growth drivers do exist, but growth rate remains contingent on evolving geopolitical disruptions to trade

HDFC Bank's Q4 FY26 results were mostly on expected lines, eliciting a muted response from markets on Monday. The bank's standalone net profit grew 9.1 per cent during the quarter, delivering an RoA of 1.9 per cent.

For FY26, profit grew 10.9 per cent, while loans and deposits rose 12 per cent and 14.4 per cent; RoA remained at 1.9 per cent just as in FY25. Consolidated profit grew 7.4 per cent.

ANALYSIS.

CD RATIO TARGET HIT

Ever since the merger with erstwhile HDFC Ltd, the bank has been hard at work, managing the high credit-deposit (CD) ratio, which shot to 108 per cent post the merger. In the Q3 FY26 earnings call, management had guided for the ratio to fall to 95 per cent by Q4 from 99 per cent then. Thanks to credit growth being lower than system (HDFC's 12 per cent vs system's 13.5-14 per cent), the bank has managed to hit a CD ratio of 95 per cent.

The management views the 14-per cent system credit growth as excessive for a 9-per cent FY26 nominal GDP growth and had to restrict loan growth to avoid potential 'landmines' (possible delinquencies).

FY27 OUTLOOK

Going into FY27, loan growth drivers do exist but growth rate remains contingent on evolving geopolitical disruptions to trade. Corporate loans which make over 25 per cent of the book is seeing good demand. The segment's 13-per cent growth outpaced the overall loan growth in FY26. The SME segment, accounting for one-fifth of the loan book is expected to continue its momentum in FY27 too. It grew about 17 per cent this fiscal.

Retail segment which accounts for the rest of the book grew just 6.5 per cent. However, it has these levers for growth. One, mortgages are now available at about 8,000 branches from the earlier 6,800-odd. Two, merger synergy is in action in the form of rising proportion of erstwhile HDFC Ltd borrowers who have a deposit account with the bank (mainly savings ac-

count). This has risen from 36 per cent to 50 per cent in the 2.5 years of merger. This unlocks cross-selling opportunities—the bank can now sell a credit card for instance, gaining insights from the customer's transactions in the said savings account.

Moderate treasury gains (about 5 per cent of net revenue in FY26) could be a headwind in FY27. G-sec yields have firmed up in the last three quarters.

The bank has so far actively managed duration (lower duration would mean lower interest rate risk) but expects only moderate treasury gains in FY27. RBI's recent *diktat* limiting open positions in the onshore currency market is expected to dent foreign trading income as well. Nevertheless, any residual repricing of term deposits (as old accounts mature and get booked at lower rates) could aid margin and thus prop RoA. Since Febru-

'RBI draft for upper layer non-banks affects CICs disproportionately'

Press Trust of India
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank's recently-released draft on upper layer non-bank finance companies (NBFCs) impacts core investment companies “disproportionately” by upping compliance costs, said a report on Monday.

India Ratings said mandatory listing requirements could prove onerous for several CICs, especially those structured primarily for promoter-level capital allocation, rather than public-market access.

It can be noted that the RBI had come out with a draft on classifying NBFCs-ULs, amid intense speculation over the fate of the CIC Tata Sons on listing, and whether the revised directions continue to make a listing necessary for the salt to software conglomerate.

DRAFT REVISIONS

Under the draft revisions, the RBI is proposing a threshold of ₹1 lakh of AUM,

over which every entity will become an NBFC-UL, and also include state-run companies in the list.

Tata Sons had assets of over ₹1.7 lakh crore as on March 2025.

“While the NBFC-UL framework is broadly benign for the sector at large, CICs emerge as the clear outliers. CICs with consolidated assets approaching or exceeding ₹1 lakh crore will face disproportionate compliance costs under the new regime,” said the rating agency.

If the framework is applied on a consolidated rather than a standalone basis for assets under management calculation, its scope would extend to several corporate groups operating under the CIC structure, many of which are privately held and unlisted.

It added that several CICs have highly concentrated investments in step-down subsidiaries and the LEF (large exposures framework) application in such cases could prove operationally challenging.

Digital insurtech firm Acko trims 60 roles in AI-led restructuring

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Digital insurtech firm Acko has let go of around 60 employees, or roughly 5 per cent of its workforce, as part of a broader structural realignment aimed at embedding artificial intelligence (AI) deeper into its operations, multiple people familiar with the matter said.

The affected employees are expected to remain with the company until the end of June, they added.

GREATER AUTOMATION

The move is part of Acko's shift towards AI-native workflows and greater automation across functions.

“Approximately 60 people out of the 1,200-person organisation will transition out as Acko realigns its teams around AI-first workflows, performance benchmarks and the skill sets required for our next phase of growth,” said a source close to development.

“This is not a cost-cutting exercise,” the source added.

The restructuring comes alongside a senior leadership change, with chief marketing officer Ashish Mishra stepping down after more than five years at the company. Mishra, who joined Acko in

August 2020, is currently serving his notice period.

He is expected to be succeeded by Nitin Khanna, a long-time executive who has spent over seven years at Acko across marketing roles, the people cited above said.

Founded in 2016 by Varun Dua and Ruchi Deepak, Acko has raised over \$450 million from investors, including Amazon, Accel and Elevation Capital, among others.

The company has been narrowing losses while scaling revenue.

In FY25, Acko reduced its consolidated net loss to ₹424 crore from ₹667 crore a year earlier, while operating revenue rose to ₹2,836 crore from ₹2,106 crore.

LEGACY PLAYERS

Acko operates in a competitive insurance market, taking on legacy players such as Tata AIG and Bajaj Allianz, as well as digital-first platforms, including Go Digit Insurance and PolicyBazaar.

BROADER SHIFT

The latest restructuring underscores a broader shift among new-age insurers towards leaner, tech-led operating models, with AI increasingly central to underwriting, claims processing and customer engagement.

AI is driving shift to autonomous, zero-touch operations: Comviva CEO

bl.interview

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

A global mobility solution provider and a 100 per cent-owned subsidiary of Tech Mahindra, Comviva has partnered with the world's leading telecom operators and enterprises and is now supporting them in their global growth objectives.

Now, under Comviva 2.0, it is also shifting from scale-led growth to platform-led, value-driven expansion, with a clear ambition to double revenue over the next three years.

Our strategy is anchored on four priorities. First is platformisation. We are evolving from point solutions to integrated, AI-powered digital platforms that enable intelligent monetisation across customer journeys. Second, deepening monetisation of our installed base.

While messaging and digital wallets remain strong and profitable, the next phase of growth lies in building value on top of these ecosystems. For instance, Yabx leverages transactional intelligence from wallet platforms to unlock digital lending opportunities for underserved consumers and small businesses. Similarly, our mobility Pay platform — processing over \$400 billion across 7.5 billion+ transactions annually — continues to expand into new financial and enterprise use cases. Third is geographic expansion. We are accelerating our presence in high-value markets such as the US, Europe,

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RAJESH CHANDIRAMANI
Chief Executive Officer, Comviva



and ANZ, complementing our strong footprint across Asia, the West Asia, and Africa. Finally, vertical diversification.

We are extending telecom-grade capabilities into sectors like retail and logistics, where real-time, personalised engagement is becoming mission-critical.

What are the key challenges and growth barriers that your customers face?

Telecom operators today face three structural challenges.

First, revenue stagnation. As connectivity becomes increasingly commoditised, operators are under sustained pressure on average revenue per user (ARPU) and must identify new digital

revenue streams. Second, legacy complexity.

Most operators run on deeply entrenched, fragmented systems built over decades.

Replacing them outright is neither commercially viable nor operationally prudent, making transformation inherently complex. Third, capability gaps.

The demand for AI and digital talent far exceeds supply, creating execution bottlenecks at a time when speed is critical. Our approach directly addresses these constraints. At the same time, we work closely with customers through co-innovation and capability-building models to bridge talent gaps.

As telcos evolve into techcos, the need is not just mod-

ernisation, but agile monetisation, real-time engagement, and new digital business models. That is where we are enabling measurable impact.

Comviva has significant market share in digital wallets, Short Message Service Centre (SMSCs), and Business Support Systems (BSSs). Where do you see the biggest opportunity to expand market share further?

Our next phase of market share expansion is driven by three high-conviction opportunities.

First, AI-native BSS transformation. As operators transition to digital service providers, there is strong demand for cloud-native, AI-driven BSS platforms.

Second, enterprise engagement platforms. In messaging and APIs, the market is rapidly commoditising at the infrastructure level.

Our focus is to move up the value chain — enabling enterprises with intelligent, programmable engagement platforms that deliver differentiated customer experiences.

Third, geographic expansion into developed markets.

Additionally, we are expanding into adjacent verticals such as retail and logistics, unlocking new revenue pools beyond telecom.

You highlighted retail and logistics as key growth verticals. What specific gaps are you addressing in these sectors?

In retail, the core challenge is not the lack of engagement channels, but the inability to orchestrate them effectively. Customer data remains fragmented, limiting personalisation at scale.

We are addressing this by enabling unified customer intelligence and real-time decisioning, enabling retailers to drive higher conversion rates, stronger retention, and improved customer lifetime value.

In logistics, the challenge is operational but rooted in communication inefficiencies.

Our unified, real-time communication platforms enable context-aware engagement across channels, improving first-attempt delivery success rates, reducing cost-to-serve, and enhancing customer experience.

We are effectively bringing telecom-grade scale and

precision into industries that are still evolving digitally.

You outlined three areas where AI is being deployed — development, operations and customer engagement. Which of these is delivering the most tangible business impact today?

While AI is embedded across development, operations, and customer engagement, the most immediate and measurable impact is in operations and customer-facing use cases. In operations, AI is enabling a shift towards autonomous, zero-touch environments, where systems can predict, detect, and resolve issues in real time.

This significantly reduces operational costs while improving reliability and scalability.

In customer engagement, AI is driving real-time, context-aware monetisation.

While AI-led development is accelerating innovation cycles, we are seeing clear near-term returns on investment in operations and customer engagement through a combination of cost efficiency, agility, and revenue uplift.

BoM profit up 35% in Q4

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

State-owned Bank of Maharashtra on Monday reported a 35 per cent rise in net profit at ₹2,014 crore in the January-March quarter of 2025-26, aided by core income and reduction in bad loans.

The Pune-headquartered bank had earned a net profit of ₹1,493 crore in the year-ago period. During the quarter, the bank's total income increased to ₹8,693 crore against ₹7,711 crore a year ago, the bank said in a regulatory filing.

Interest income grew to ₹7,755 crore during the period under review, from ₹6,731 crore in the corresponding quarter a year ago. Net Interest Income (NII) grew by 19 per cent to ₹3,702 crore as against ₹3,116 crore during the same quarter a year ago. The growth in NII was due to a 22 per cent increase in loans to ₹2.92 lakh crore in the fourth quarter ended March 2026. However, the bank reported a 14 per cent rise in total deposits to ₹3.50 lakh crore in the reporting quarter, up from ₹3.07 lakh crore at the end of the fourth quarter of the previous financial year.

QUICKLY.

US-Iran tensions, strong \$ push gold to 1-week low

Bengaluru: Gold prices were down on Monday after falling to a one-week low earlier in the session as the dollar and oil prices climbed on Iran's threat of retaliation in response to the US takeover of an Iranian cargo vessel. US gold futures for June delivery fell 0.8 per cent to \$4,839.10. The dollar rose to its peak in a week before paring gains. REUTERS

Copper slips on US-Iran ceasefire doubts

Copper lost ground on Monday as the Strait of Hormuz closed to marine traffic once more and a fragile ceasefire between Iran and the US looked in jeopardy, reigniting fears over economic growth. The metal had gained 3.9 per cent last week on optimism that the ceasefire may hold and Iran's declaration on Friday that the Strait had been reopened to commercial vessels. REUTERS

Wheat export quota doubled to 5 mt

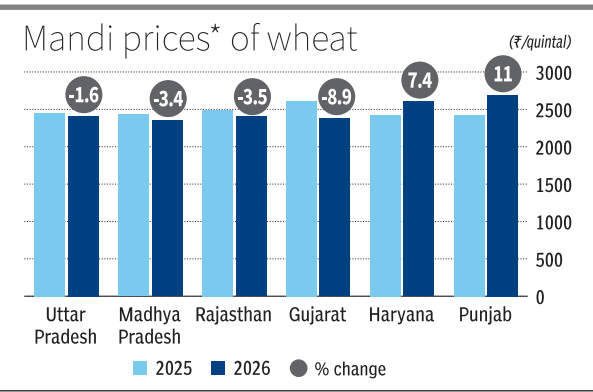
FACTORED IN. Move follows comprehensive review of current production, stock availability and price trends

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Amid growing farmer dissatisfaction over low mandi prices, the government has decided to permit the export of an additional 2.5 million tonnes (mt) of wheat, doubling the total allowed volume to 5 mt. While a formal notification from the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) is pending, the move follows approval from a high-powered inter-ministerial committee. Although the 2022 export ban remains in place, India continues to fulfil shipments to friendly nations based on diplomatic requests. “The Government of India has approved the export of an additional 2.5 mt of wheat, reinforcing its commitment to ensuring remunerative returns for farmers while maintaining stability in domestic markets. The de-

cision follows a comprehensive review of current production, stock availability, and price trends,” the Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution said in a statement Monday. Wheat acreage during the rabi 2026 season has increased to approximately 334.17 lakh hectares, compared to 328.04 lakh hectares last year. This rise reflects strong farmer confidence in wheat cultivation, supported by assured minimum support price (MSP) and robust procurement mechanisms, and indicates the likelihood of another strong harvest, it said.

LOWER THAN LAST YEAR Although the government increased wheat MSP by 6.6 per cent to ₹2,585/quintal during the 2025-26 crop year (July-June) against ₹2,425/quintal in 2024-25, the prevailing rates in mandis in Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pra-



des, Gujarat and Rajasthan are lower than the benchmark price as well as from year-ago levels. But farmers in only Punjab and Haryana are able to receive the MSP for their wheat due to public procurement through a strong mandi infrastructure. Rahul Chauhan of I-Grain consultancy said that the sentiment in India's wheat market is now gradually

turning positive. “A clearer trend of quality-based pricing is likely to emerge in the near future,” he said in a note referring to crop damage due to unseasonal rains and hailstorms. The quality of the produce has been affected, with grains turning discoloured and black in many areas, he said, adding that arrivals in mandis have started to decline. Besides, increased

moisture content has altered supply dynamics in the market. The price gap between good and lower quality wheat is expected to widen, he said. “There are indications that in the long term, prices of good-quality wheat may increase by ₹100-150 per quintal. But, in the short term, prices may remain under pressure due to ongoing harvesting across the country and the likelihood of higher arrivals in the coming weeks,” he said. The DGFT, in a notification on February 24, had said that the export policy of wheat (HS Codes 10011900 and 10019910) continues to remain ‘Prohibited’, but export of 2.5 mt is permitted. Detailed modalities for the purpose were notified through a separate public notice on the same day. Exporters need to to apply for permits online during a window of first 10 days of each month.

Akshaya Tritiya lifts gold jewellery sales to 20 tonnes

Our Bureau
Mumbai

A sharp drop in gold prices in the days leading up to Akshaya Tritiya lifted jewellery demand across India, with buyers stepping in to make purchases on the auspicious day on Sunday. According to data from the Indian Bullion and Jewellery Association, 22-carat gold prices fell to ₹1,38,916 per 10 g on Friday, down from ₹1,40,245 on Thursday, prompting a surge in buying activity. Rajesh Rokde, Chairman, All India Gem and Jewellery Domestic Council, said the overall trade across India was strong, with 18-20 tonnes of business recorded by jewellers. With gold prices rising from around ₹90,000 last year to about ₹1,54,000 per 10 g now, the sector's attraction has increased significantly, he said. Gradually, people have understood the benefits of systematic investment buying on every auspicious occasion.



People have understood the benefits of buying on every auspicious occasion, said an industry expert RAHUL SHARMA

the ongoing wedding season continues,” he said.

PIVOTAL INTEGRATION Ramesh Kalyanaraman, Executive Director, Kalyan Jewellers, said demand during Akshaya Tritiya had been robust since the start of the muhurat with a steady influx of customers at showrooms. The strategic integration with quick-commerce platforms, such as Swiggy Instamart, had been pivotal in ensuring high accessibility for convenience-led and last-minute purchases, he said. Consumer preferences are rapidly evolving and this reflected in the growing affinity of the young first-time buyers for lightweight practical jewellery, especially diamond-studded pieces in 9k, 14k, and 18k categories, said Colin Shah, MD, Kama Jewellery. The industry has witnessed about 15 per cent year-on-year spike sales, with healthy ticket size and renewed confidence among buyers towards the precious metal, he said.

RISE IN REVENUE PN Gadgil Jewellers recorded revenue of ₹251 crore on Akshaya Tritiya, up 80 per cent from last year's ₹140 crore. It was the company's second-highest single-day revenue performance to date. Dr Saurabh Gadgil, Chairman and MD, said gold remained the key driver recording 80 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) revenue growth, while revenues of the silver and diamond segments grew by 98 per cent and 80 per cent y-o-y, respectively. “We have started the quarter on a strong footing and are well-positioned as

Sourcing used cooking oil for biodiesel production a challenge: Study

Our Bureau
New Delhi

A FICCI-commissioned study has pointed out significant gaps in the procurement of used cooking oils (UCO), currently used for biodiesel production. Out of 72 registered biodiesel production units, about 40 per cent do not have any formal linkage with any UCO aggregator, while 19 are linked to a single aggregator. Another 10 are linked to two aggregators and 14 are connected with 3-11 aggregators. Besides, there are also

17 bio-diesel plants that act as aggregators of UCO. “This distribution points to limited redundancy and low resilience in UCO mobilisation. A mature aggregation ecosystem typically requires multiple aggregators operating within a catchment area. The observed concentration of plants with zero or minimal aggregator linkages reflects an underdeveloped aggregation layer, rather than saturation or efficiency,” the study said. Titled “Transitioning the Chemical Industry: Used Cooking Oil as a Renewable Feedstock for Enabling In-

dia's Material Transition”, the study recommended mandatory collection of UCO necessary for scale. Enforcement can quickly improve collection, but without integrated allocation logic, system value may be lost or exported, it said. **PRACTICE ELSEWHERE** China, the study said, generates large volumes of waste cooking oil (WCO) due to dietary patterns and urban scale. “The Chinese government has implemented strict enforcement against illegal re-use. Centralised collection systems, municipal in-

volvement and licensing have significantly reduced food chain leakage in major cities. However, downstream allocation remains fragmented. A large share of legally recovered WCO is converted into biodiesel, with significant volumes exported. Only recently have oleochemical and chemical applications begun to emerge domestically, enabled by improved purification technologies and tightening environmental controls,” it said. In the US, UCO, which is known as “yellow grease”, is mobilised primarily through

mandatory grease disposal requirements applied to commercial food-service establishments at State and municipal levels. These requirements ensure high recovery from restaurants, industrial kitchens and institutional food providers, supported by licensed private collectors. **VULNERABILITIES** Sustainable aviation fuel (SAF) can also earn incentives under the same framework, though there are no equivalent policy instruments in the US that recognise or prioritise chemical or

material applications of UCO. The study said that the recent geopolitical tensions in West Asia had further highlighted India's vulnerability to disruptions in crude oil supply and price volatility. For the chemical sector, this exposure extends beyond energy to material inputs, particularly for high-volume products such as surfactants and polymers. In this context, increasing the use of domestic, biogenic feedstock offers a pathway to strengthen supply-chain resilience while reducing the dependence on imported crude-derived carbon, it said.

In letter to Goyal, Punjab's basmati exporters seek overhaul of sector's development body

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Punjab Rice Millers Exporters Association has urged Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal to order a restructuring of the Basmati Export Development Foundation (BEDF), currently governed by the government's agri export promotion body Apeda, and initiate necessary reforms on priority. The BEDF has been in the limelight ever since it hiked the mandatory contract registration fee by over 100 per cent last year. **CONFLICT: FEE HIKE** The association, in a letter to Apeda in September 2025, had termed the fee hike — to ₹70/tonne from ₹30/tonne (excluding GST) — as an “unusual increase”, and highly arbitrary, which would burden the trade, and demanded its immediate



withdrawal. A similar representation was also made by Haryana's basmati exporters. The government, however, implemented the revised fee, which has resurfaced amid reduced margins and blocked capital due to the West Asia crisis. “Several structural flaws have cropped up in the present BEDF setup, which require urgent reforms to bring the focus back on the production and promotion of quality basmati grain,” said Ashok Sethi, Director, PRMEA. He said even though the decision of reforms of BEDF were dis-

Basmati Export Development Foundation has been in the news since it hiked the mandatory contract fee by over 100%

cussed and accepted by the BEDF Board on several occasions in the past, no action had been taken by Apeda. “BEDF's complete review is urgently required by holding wider consultations with all stakeholders, including major rice exporters and agro processing units based in Punjab and Haryana,” Sethi said. He suggested that a ‘High Power Task Committee’ be constituted for detailed discussions with basmati exporters. **AGE OF OFFICIALS** PRMEA also brought up the “bureaucratic” nature of

BEDF which, it said, is headed by retired officials on short-term contracts. It, thus, also sought that the maximum age limit for the BEDF Director's be fixed at 60 years, so that the person appointed could execute long-term plans. The association further alleged that though the BEDF had accumulated a large corpus from the contract registration fee for the protection of basmati GI, it had remained elusive in potential countries where registration had not been done yet. “It is important that a thorough review is conducted to overhaul the BEDF. We would appreciate your immediate response,” the PRMEA said in its letter to Goyal. India exported 6.07 mt of basmati rice during April-Feb of FY26, the same as in FY25. In value terms, exports were \$5.27 billion (₹46,403 crore) till Feb in FY26.

Global steel demand to rise despite W. Asia war

Our Bureau
Chennai

Though the ongoing West Asia conflict poses a risk, the global steel demand is poised to rise marginally by 0.3 per cent to 1,724 million tonnes (mt) in 2026. This will be followed by an accelerated growth of 2.2 per cent in 2027 to reach 1,762 mt, according to the short-range outlook (SRO) released by the World Steel Association. However, the ongoing conflict might have a negative impact on the demand of that region in 2026. After a protracted period of decline, all major developed economies, including the European Union, the US, Canada, Japan and Korea, are expected to post positive growth in 2027. Consequently, global steel demand, excluding China, is expected to grow 4 per cent in 2027. While this outlook reflects data available as of mid-March 2026, the escalating West Asia conflict



presents a significant stress test. The developed world's steel demand grew by 0.2 per cent in 2025, marking the end of a three-year consecutive decline since 2021. The outlook expects this stabilisation to pave the way for a gradual recovery, with growth reaching 1 per cent in 2026 and gaining further momentum to 2.3 per cent in 2027. **ASEAN ECONOMIES** Steel demand growth across developing economies, excluding China, is projected to moderate to a 2.5 per cent

pace in 2026, a significant deceleration from the roughly 5 per cent annual growth recorded in recent years. This cooling is primarily driven by a sharp contraction in West Asia, where regional conflict has abruptly reversed previous growth expectations. Further, the forecast predicts normalisation of demand across ASEAN economies. Following a strong expansion in 2025, growth in this region is expected to temporarily soften as stockpiling activity subsides. However, the outlook for 2027 is more robust, with growth forecast to rebound to 5.1 per cent. The ongoing West Asia conflict might have a negative impact on the demand in that region in 2026. Alfonso Hidalgo Calcerada, Chief Economist, UNESID, and Chair of the Worldsteel Economics Committee, said: “Our latest forecasts validate the trajectory established in our October 2025 SRO, confirming that global steel demand is

bottoming out over the 2025-2026 period. This follows a protracted and challenging phase of global structural adjustments that has suppressed demand since 2022. We are now transitioning to a path of modest growth in 2026, with a more pronounced acceleration projected for 2027. This broader recovery is being driven by distinct shifts in regional dynamics.” **CHINA & INDIA** In China, the rate of demand contraction is finally decelerating in 2026, while demand growth across key developing markets, most notably India, remains vibrant, he added. India maintains its position as the world's fastest-growing major steel market, with demand projected to expand by 7.4 per cent in 2026 and accelerate to 9.2 per cent in 2027. This robust outlook is underpinned by broad-based strength across all key steel-consuming sectors.

Exporters' support lifts orthodox leaf prices at Coonoor tea auctions

Our Bureau
Kochi

Support from exporters lifted the prices of some orthodox leaf grades at the Coonoor tea auctions. However, prices of other grades remained at the same level in sale 16, which witnessed subdued demand from blenders. Traders said that the auction is witnessing reduced offerings as rising temperatures have hit tea production. Global Tea Auctioneers said the leaf grade sales were 84 per cent of the offered quantity of 14,08,201 kg, while dust grades maintained 89 per cent sales of 4,74,137 kg. **PRICE SURGE** In the CTC leaf, the high-priced teas and better liquoring sorts were barely steady to dearer by ₹4-5 a kg and much more at times in line

with quality; occasionally, some lots sold lower by ₹3-₹4. The better medium sorts were barely steady to dearer by ₹1-2. In leaf orthodox, the primary whole leaf grades were barely steady to occasionally dearer by ₹2-₹3 per kg and occasionally some lots sold easier by ₹2-₹3 also. Prices of broken were lower by ₹1-₹2. In CTC dust, the high-priced teas and better liquoring sorts were easier by ₹4-₹5. The better medium sorts had fair demand and sold steadily to dearer by ₹1-₹2. The mediums sort sold barely steady around the last levels. The plainer sorts were easier by ₹2-₹3 with some withdrawals. The primary orthodox dust grades were barely steady to occasionally dearer by ₹2-₹3. The secondaries and finer dusts were barely steady around levels seen in the last auctions.

Fish waste turns high-value biomedical material

Tech to convert the waste into graft materials for bone, dental healing

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

What was once discarded as foul-smelling residue at fish markets is now being reimaged as a valuable resource for advanced healthcare applications. Scientists at the ICAR-Central Institute of Fisheries Technology (ICAR-CIFT), Kochi, have patented a technology that converts fish scale waste into nano fibre-based graft materials capable of accelerating bone and dental healing. India's fish production stands at over 19 million tonnes annually, generating an estimated 4-6 million tonnes of waste. Traditionally, this biomass was used for low-value applications, such as fish meal, or simply discarded. However, scientists are now viewing it as a rich bio-



FISHY AFFAIR. India's fish production stands at over 19 mt annually, generating 4-6 mt of waste REUTERS

logical resource containing collagen, calcium compounds and bioactive molecules. **COMMON FACTOR** Fish scales are emerging as a key source of hydroxyapatite, a mineral that resembles human bone and tooth enamel. Using an advanced electro-spinning process, researchers convert this material into ultra-thin nano fibres that function as scaffolds for tissue regeneration.

These nanofibres support healing by enabling the attachment and growth of bone-forming cells. They also allow controlled delivery of antimicrobial and anti-inflammatory agents, reducing infection risks and improving recovery outcomes in dental and orthopaedic procedures. Components like skin, bones, scales and even shellfish residue contain distinct compounds that can be harnessed for industrial applications.

Countries like Japan and Norway have demonstrated the economic potential of converting fish waste into high-value products through efficient segregation and processing systems. In India, however, fragmented supply chains and limited value addition continue to constrain such opportunities. The CIFT innovation points to the emergence of a circular bio-economy model, where waste streams are reintegrated into productive use. Even partial conversion of fish waste into biomedical-grade materials could generate significant economic returns while reducing environmental burden. **JOB CREATION** It also opens new avenues for research, entrepreneurship and employment in coastal regions.

Natural gas: Go long, accumulate on dips

Gurumurthy K
bl Research Bureau

Natural gas prices have been coming down over the last few weeks. The contract touched a low of ₹240.40 per mmbtu last week and bounced from there. It is currently trading at ₹253 per mmbtu. **OUTLOOK** The price action last week shows that the pace of fall has slowed down. On the daily chart, a turn-around is visible. **COMMODITY CALL.** On the charts, there is a long-term support coming around ₹238. The recent bounce from the low of ₹240.40 last week is happening from just above this support. All these signal good chances of a rise in the com-

ing days. We will get to know whether or not this is going to be a corrective rise or a bullish reversal. Immediate support is around ₹248. Below that, ₹238 will be the next important support. The MCX natural gas contract can rise to ₹263. The price action thereafter will need close watch. Failure to breach ₹263 and a reversal thereafter could drag the contract down to ₹250 and ₹240 again. On the other hand, a strong break above ₹263 could then take the price further up to ₹275-₹280. Such a rise will give an early indication of a bullish trend reversal. **TRADE STRATEGY** Traders can go long now at ₹253. Accumulate on dips at ₹249. Keep the stop-loss at ₹246. Revise the stop-loss up to ₹255 and ₹258 when the contract goes up to ₹257 and ₹260 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹262.

QUICKLY.

ED raids premises in crypto-linked PMLA case

Bengaluru: The Enforcement Directorate on Monday raided the premises of the two sons of Karnataka Congress MLA NA Haris, Mohammed Haris Nalapad and Omar Farook Nalapad, and an alleged crypto hacker Srikrishna Ramesh, alias Sriki, in a crypto currency-linked money laundering case, officials said. A dozen premises in the city are being searched under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act. The case stems from FIRs and chargesheets filed in a 2017 case of hacking websites. PTI

IIT-M, FedEx try out intracity drone deliveries

Chennai: FedEx, along with the Indian Institute of Technology-Madras, has completed India's first intra-city drone delivery trials in Bengaluru. The trial established that a 53-km road journey, which typically takes over 60 minutes, can be replaced by an aerial route of approximately 39-42 km taking 21 minutes. OUR BUREAU

South Korean tech giant NAVER Corp, TCS ink MoU



New Delhi: South Korean tech giant NAVER Corp and India's largest IT company Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) on Monday inked a memorandum of understanding for mutual cooperation in map services. The MoU was one among 16 agreements signed at the India-Korea Business Forum, aimed at strengthening bilateral cooperation. PTI

Haryana drugs regulator seizes fake Mounjaro in Gurugram, says Eli Lilly

PROTECTING PATIENTS. Pharma major said it is supporting probe into seizure, reported to be worth ₹70 lakh

Our Bureau
Mumbai

American healthcare company Eli Lilly said it has been alerted on the seizure of “suspicious and counterfeit products” that allegedly carry its product brand name Mounjaro (Tirzepatide). Mounjaro is prescribed to treat obesity and has been in the headlines, as the scramble for GLP-1 drugs for weight-loss and diabetes get fuelled beyond the doctor's chambers, through peer-pressure and online hard-sell, among others. “The said seizure resulted from an enforcement drive conducted in Gurugram by officials from the state drugs regulatory authority, Haryana,” an Eli Lilly and Com-

pany (India) spokesperson told *businessline*. The company was responding to reports that ₹70 lakh worth of fake Mounjaro had been seized in Gurugram. This comes on the heels of an international investigation into the alleged supply of tampered/counterfeit cancer medicine and diversion of supply chains in countries, including India. **SUPPORTS PROBE** Lilly, meanwhile, said it welcomed the regulatory authority's action against “illicit medicines.” Further, it added, “We are actively supporting the investigation and will continue to work with regulatory and law enforcement authorities worldwide to protect patients from the risks of counterfeit products.



MARKET DEMAND. A Mounjaro injection used for weight loss procedures at a clinic (file photo) REUTERS

Stronger, coordinated enforcement must be sustained if we are to protect patients from unsafe fake medicines.” Mounjaro has been pegging over ₹100 crore sales in India over the last several months, and has been lead-

been seeing an increase in demand, after a patent on semaglutide from Danish healthcare company Novo Nordisk went off patent, late March. The loss of patent has resulted in over 26 domestic brands being launched in over 10 days — and at prices between 50 to 80 per cent of the innovator price. And this has further fuelled the demand for these products.

NSQ DRUGS Meanwhile, in a separate listing of Not of Standard Quality (NSQ) and spurious drugs, for March-2026, the Indian drug regulator said, that the Central Drugs Laboratories had identified 48 drug samples to be NSQ, while State Drugs Testing Laboratories identified 120 drugs samples.

Paediatrics academy chief reaffirms ORS recommendation

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

As discussions on oral rehydration salts (ORS) and corporate funding of medical events continue to dominate conversations in the doctor community, the Indian Academy of Paediatrics chief has sought to reiterate its position on ORS, besides clarifying on “academic grants” from companies. ORS is a drug, while electrolyte drinks are food products that can never be used as a substitute for ORS, said IAP National President Neelam Mohan. As paediatricians, IAP's stand is to be with science and “we do not have to talk about electrolyte drinks and



Children with oral rehydration packets in Salem (file photo)

confuse the public,” Dr Mohan told *businessline*. IAP is appreciative of the Centre's directive allowing only products adhering to the World Health Organisation's ORS formula to carry ‘ORS’ branding on their

packs, she said. Pointing out that IAP only recommends WHO-ORS for clinical use and does not promote electrolyte drinks or health beverages, she said branding of food products was outside its purview.

Dr Mohan is also Senior Director (pediatric gastroenterology and hepatology), Medanta Medicity (Gurugram).

ACADEMIC GRANTS Addressing the contentious issue of corporate funding, Mohan said “academic grants”, when taken from companies, are in compliance with the IMS Act, UCMPM and NMC guidelines and do not influence the IAP's scientific content or recommendations. [The IMS Act is the Infant Milk Substitutes, Feeding Bottles and Infant Foods (Regulation of Production, Supply and Distribution) Act; UCMPM is the Uniform Code for Pharmaceutical Marketing Practices; and the

NMC Act is the National Medical Commission Act.] The IAP President was responding to concerns being discussed among members of the paediatric community, following the resignation of Dr Sivaranjani Santosh from the IAP about a week ago. Dr Santosh had flagged the issues of corporate funding besides calling for clear differentiation between ORS products (mandated to abide by the WHO formula), and electrolyte drinks that are food products. Looking to counter further criticism, Dr Mohan said that the IAP represents over 50,000 doctors who reiterate that children's health is a priority, and has always warned against non-standard formulations.

Building a ₹600-cr activewear biz, the Technosport way

T E Raja Simhan
Tiruppur

Leaving a stable job at Microsoft in 2007, at a time when the IT sector was booming, Sunil Jhunhunwala took a leap of faith into entrepreneurship. Armed with just ₹20 lakh in family savings, he entered the textile industry to launch Technosport in Tiruppur, a decision that has since transformed into a ₹600 crore activewear business, now eyeing ₹1,000 crore in revenue this fiscal. In its early years, Technosport was not a manufacturer but a trader. The company sourced synthetic fabrics from hubs such as Ludhiana and Silvassa, got garments stitched in Tiruppur and sold them under its own label. The founding insight was straightforward: While global brands such as Nike, Adidas and Reebok were gaining popularity in India, their products remained unaffordable for most con-



Sunil Jhunhunwala, Co-founder, TechnoSport BUOY GHOSH

sumers. Technosport sought to bridge that gap by “democratising” performance wear — offering comfort, durability and functionality at accessible price points. **EARLY YEARS** However, the journey was far from smooth. In the beginning, while the company could replicate the look of global products, it struggled to match their performance. The turning point came in 2010, when Jhunhunwala visited textile expos in China

In the beginning, while the company could replicate the look of global products, it struggled to match their performance

and Taiwan. There, he gained insights into the science behind high-performance fabrics, particularly moisture management and durability — key differentiators for global brands. The company moved from merely sourcing fabrics to understanding and engineering them. Over time, it invested in building in-house capabilities, focusing on synthetic fibres suited to India's climate and lifestyle, Sunil Jhunhunwala, Co-founder at TechnoSport, told *businessline* at his factory inside the Perundurai Sipcot Industrial Estate, near Tiruppur.

The brand also repositioned itself from “sportswear” to “activewear” — a broader category catering not just to athletes but everyday users, including office-goers, delivery personnel and farmers. This shift significantly expanded its market in a price-sensitive country such as India. Today, Technosport operates a vertically integrated fabric manufacturing facility in and around Tiruppur with a capacity of about 30 tonnes per day, translating into over 1.2 lakh garments. While garmenting continues to be outsourced, control over fabric production — its key differentiator — has enabled the company to maintain both quality and cost efficiency. Sustainability has emerged as another pillar of growth. The company's plant runs on renewable energy, adheres to zero liquid discharge norms and focuses on reducing its carbon footprint.

As Ladakh ramps up apricot exports, post harvest infra remains a concern

Guizar Bhat
Srinagar

Ladakh's famed apricots are set to return to global markets this season, with the Union Territory administration signing a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the UAE-based retail major Lulu Group to export 1,000 tonnes of the fruit, beginning July. The agreement marks the second such export initiative from the cold desert region. Under the MoU, two premium varieties — Raktsey Karpo, a GI-tagged variety, and Halman — will be exported. Both are prized for their taste and suitability for fresh consumption and processing. Officials acknowledge that logistics, particularly cold-chain infrastructure, remains a key challenge. Apricots are highly perish-



SUPPLY BOTTLENECK. Officials acknowledge that logistics, particularly cold-chain infrastructure, remains a key challenge

able and require efficient post-harvest handling, including grading, storage and refrigerated transport, to maintain quality during long-distance shipments. However, a senior official said the region has developed some capacity to address these concerns. “A storage facility with a capacity of 1,000 tonnes has been constructed,” the official said, adding that additional solar-powered cold storage units are planned to strengthen preservation cap-

abilities in remote areas. The push for solar-powered facilities reflects Ladakh's unique geography, where energy access can be inconsistent and conventional cold storage systems are difficult to operate at scale. **MAJOR PRODUCER** Tsewang Phunchok, Director of the Horticulture Department, Ladakh, told *businessline* that this is the second time apricot shipments are being exported

from the region. “This year, however, the quantity will be much higher,” he said. Known for producing high-quality organic apricots, Ladakh accounts for more than 60 per cent of India's total output of the fruit. Around 2,612 hectares are under apricot cultivation, with annual production estimated about 15,858 tonnes, according to official data. Apricot cultivation supports between 40,000 and 60,000 people in the region, with thousands more dependent on associated sectors such as processing, trade and tourism. While the export push is expected to boost incomes, its success will hinge on whether Ladakh can scale up its storage and cold-chain infrastructure in the future to handle larger volumes without compromising on quality.

Need for AI-ready datasets will shake-up the job ecosystem in India: S&P Global executive

bl.interview

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

In the AI age where data is the new oil, companies need a more sophisticated workforce to build their ‘virtual refinery’, i.e., employees who can make company data AI-ready. The demand for this line of work is expected to blow up in a big way in the coming years. Saugata Saha, President, Market Intelligence & Chief Enterprise Data Officer, S&P Global, talks about the demand for such refined data, advising aspirants to brush up on AI tools and related skill sets to become an asset to organisations. Edited excerpts:

How AI-ready are enterprise data sets currently?

Machines need to look at the data and identify it and its various components. For that, you need metadata. We are investing a lot of money in building out metadata for all our data sets. Further, there is the challenge of connecting data in different places in the organisation or within the same department. Organisations, generally speaking, are far behind on what needs to be done to build out these capabilities. We are building out a connected data fabric, which makes distribution and AI-driven use cases easier, and new tools such as MCP Connectors to help AI models read from our data with a high level of certainty. So, there's a lot of work organisations need to do to catch up.

Do you feel that this is

going to lead to newer jobs? Absolutely. Over 10-15 years ago, there weren't really any meaningful data engineer roles. Those are new roles that have come up, and we go through a similar cycle where new roles emerge. There will be new roles around a lot of other fundamental roles; how researchers and software engineers work will change. Rather than doing solo work, AI tools will help them be more productive. It's going to be a bit of a change management exercise as well because people who can't keep up or embrace these new tools might suddenly find themselves much less productive than their counterparts and colleagues. What's different this time is that the timelines to adapt are far more compressed. So, it'll be a significant expectation for people to adapt to

“We label our products very clearly because ours is a business of selling trusted data and research

SAUGATA SAHA
President, Market Intelligence & Chief Enterprise Data Officer, S&P Global



these new tools and technologies or be left behind in the workforce. **Everyone is talking about a human + AI model. How does that harmonisation work?** There are two parts: How people use AI to become more productive and agentic workflows. We are empowering all major personas with these new tools to be more

productive within limited time, cover more topics, have higher quality output and do research that would be hard for a human due to the consumption of huge data. There's also a focus on the responsible use of AI and ensuring customers understand AI deployment. We label our products very clearly because ours is a business of selling trusted data and re-

search, and we want to retain trust. In the future, we can see even in our own workflows the potential application of agents to do straight-through processing of simple workloads. **Are there any particular roles that agents can completely take over?** A big factor in answering that question is time. Potentially, agents can run some workflows in data extraction from structured financial filings. Very structured, regimented agents can do that within reason. Those are some areas where agents can run within the next 12 to 18 months. There are much more complex workflows like risk management, investment decisions, etc., for which the timelines are unclear. **What skill sets should employees or applicants**

develop to prepare for the AI role? The best skill set they have is a high level of fluency and proficiency in all of these new tools and technologies. Not everybody has to be an expert: Can you use X tool to build an agent to simplify three things you do every day? Can you use X to quickly spot and identify bugs and fix them? Can you use X tool? People who can do that will have more opportunities. **Going forward, how do you see the AI-grade data market evolving?** Both the demand and supply of AI-ready data will grow exponentially. What will also happen simultaneously is that the non-AI-ready data market is going to shrink over time because all customers will become more productive, and their primary demand would be

AI-ready data. For large industries, especially the sophisticated ones who work a lot with data, this creates new opportunities to be more productive and serve customers in new ways. Both because of what's going to happen with proximity to data centres and the raw talent available here, India finds itself in a very promising position to capitalise on this boom.

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thehindu **businessline.**

Centre extends over ₹460 crore financial support to Alliance Air

FUNDING AID. The loan will be used to restore grounded fleet and revive the regional player

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi



NEW FLIGHT PATH. The airline is working to restore operations and is in discussions with aircraft manufacturer ATR regarding spare parts and maintenance support

The Centre has decided to provide over ₹460 crore in financial support to Alliance Air to help the regional carrier restore grounded aircraft, as well as revive its operations, sources told *businessline*.

Accordingly, the assistance has been extended in the form of a loan, sources said, adding that the amount will be disbursed in three tranches linked to operational milestones achieved by the airline.

Speaking to *businessline*, sources said the first instalment of ₹150 crore was recently released to the airline.

This tranche will be followed by a second instalment of ₹150 crore, while the remaining ₹160 crore will be provided as the third and final instalment under the

programme to revive the state-owned airline.

ENGINE SERVICING

Notably, the funding support comes at a time when a large part of the airline's fleet has remained grounded amid challenges related to sourcing spare parts and engine servicing.

According to sources, delays in payments to original equipment manufacturers, lessors, and main-

tenance, repair, and overhaul service providers have aggravated the operational challenges.

However, the airline is working to restore operations and is in discussions with aircraft manufacturer ATR regarding spare parts and maintenance support.

REGIONAL ROUTES

Fleet-wise, the government-owned carrier operates 21 aircraft on regional routes,

including 20 ATR aircraft and one Dornier 228.

At present, 11 of the regional player's aircraft are grounded, while 10 remain operational.

STATE BAILOUTS

As of now, the airline has been kept afloat by state bailouts, as its earnings are used to repay vendors and meet other obligations.

In 2023, the central government infused ₹600 crore worth of additional equity into the airline.

Besides, sources told *businessline* that the total debt is estimated to be approximately ₹4,000 crore.

The airline was an erstwhile part of Air India prior to the latter's divestment. It was founded in 1996 as a wholly-owned subsidiary of the then Indian Airlines, which later merged with Air India.

Sources said that most of

the debt and a few other liabilities were onboarded after the divestment of Air India.

Consequently, its debt is primarily owed to Air India Assets Holding Ltd (AIAHL), OMCs and other vendors.

In 2021, after the Tata Group bought the debt-ridden Air India from the government, Alliance Air was left as the only airline under the Centre's control.

MARGINAL SHARE

As per the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) data, Alliance Air continues to hold a marginal share of India's domestic aviation market.

In February 2026, the airline carried around 0.11 lakh passengers, accounting for about 0.4 per cent of the domestic market.

At present, Alliance Air operates a majority of its routes under the regional connectivity scheme UDAN.

POSH complaints edge higher; major under-reporting feared

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

A year-on-year rise in complaints under the Prevention of Sexual Harassment (POSH) regime across India's top listed companies suggests improved reporting awareness but also points to the existence of persistent systemic issues in the corporate world.

DATA FOCUS.

A *businessline* analysis of data sourced from primeinfobase.com shows that POSH cases in Nifty500 companies were up 13 per cent year-on-year in FY25 at 2,583 complaints compared to 2,276 complaints in FY24. The figure was at 1,779 in FY23.

Further, across the three fiscal years (FY23, FY24 and FY25), the percentage of complaints upheld out of the total complaints was in the range of 66-69 per cent.

TCS (125), Wipro (125), ICICI Bank (117), Indigo (79) and HDFC Bank (75) are companies with the maximum number of absolute POSH complaints in FY25. Sectorally, financial services, information technology (IT) and consumer companies led in the share of complaints.

However, 212 of the Nifty500 companies, all of whom have significantly high workforce levels, reported zero POSH complaints in FY25, and 147 companies reported less than five POSH complaints in the fiscal.

WORKPLACE CULTURE

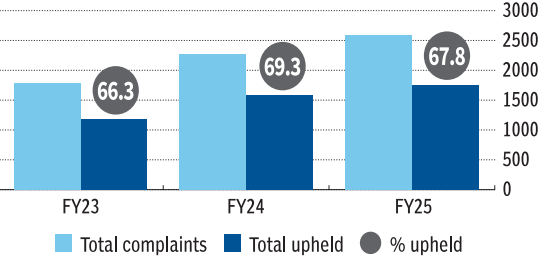
HR and legal experts told *businessline* that while the increase in complaints point to stronger implementation of POSH policies and greater employee sensitisation, the relatively low number of reported cases across India's top 500 companies suggests significant under-reporting due to stigma and workplace culture issues.

Preetha Soman, Partner, JSA Advocates & Solicitors, said there had been a significant improvement in reporting under POSH, especially in larger companies, but it is not uniformly robust across companies. "Many employees still weigh the emotional, professional and social cost of reporting, before coming forward. That hesitation is particularly visible in cases involving senior respondents, influential business leaders, rainmakers or close-knit team environments, where the complainant may fear isolation or subtle retaliation," she said.

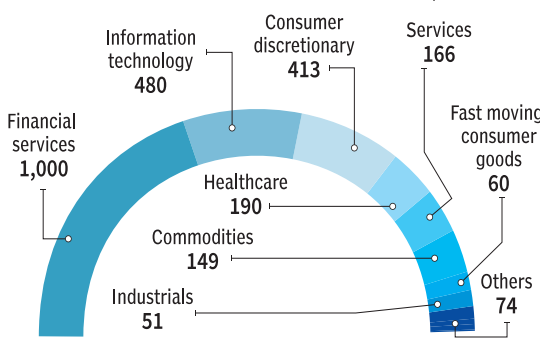
Vasanthi Srinivasan, Pro-

Awareness drive paying off

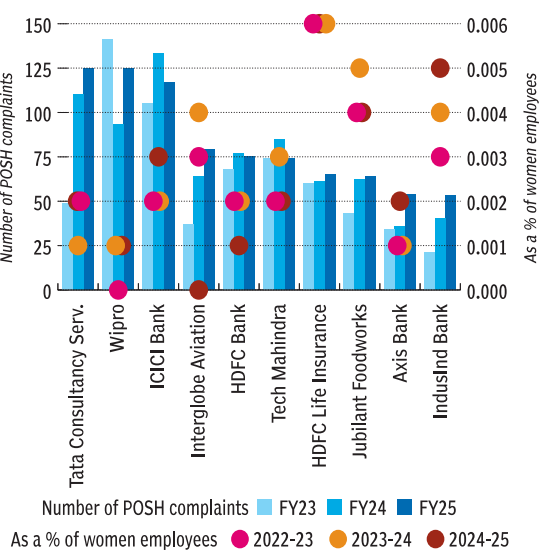
Summary of POSH cases among Nifty500 companies



Sectoral mix



Top 10 companies as per FY25 POSH cases



Source: primeinfobase.com

‘Bengaluru continues to lead India’s GCC growth’

bl.interview

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Priyank M Kharge, Karnataka's Rural Development and Panchayat Raj, IT and Biotechnology Minister, said the State has so far funded over 1,300 start-ups through various initiatives. He said moving forward, the government is evaluating deep-tech-related investments. He also addressed Karnataka's development as India's GCC hub, the importance of reskilling talent, and the proposed regulations on social media.

Edited excerpts:

Karnataka has seen some momentum across GCCs, ITs, and start-ups recently. What incentives have driven this, and how does the State compare with others?

Very few GCCs reach out for incentives. What worked is the depth of Karnataka's talent pool and a dedicated GCC policy that hand-holds them. Within the policy, we have started something called the Katalyst, an end-to-end hand-holding for the GCC. Depending on the sector, whether they're inter-

ested in land, skilling people, incentives, more subsidies, partnering with government accelerators, incubators, or fostering talent away from educational institutions, we do the whole 360-degree approach with them. That is the biggest advantage we have over others. In the last year, we have had 31 GCC-related investments. Bengaluru continues to lead India's GCC growth, accounting for a significant share of around 9.1 million square feet leased in Q1 2026. The most heartening thing is that almost all the new disruptive companies — be it the likes of Mistral AI or Anthropic — have chosen Bengaluru to be their home. That has been encouraging for us.

How do Karnataka's semiconductor ambitions compare with a state like Gujarat, which is already attracting significant investments?

Karnataka has more than 60 per cent of the country's ESDM talent pool, alongside large-scale integration models. In terms of design, we are number one.

While we have the talent and the right policy, we are missing out on manufacturing because of the central government's focus on its



The most heartening thing is that almost all the new disruptive companies — be it the likes of Mistral AI or Anthropic — have chosen Bengaluru to be their home

PRIYANK M KHARGE
Rural Development and Panchayat Raj, IT and Biotechnology Minister

states by playing favourites.

On start-ups, several funds have been announced recently. How much has been deployed so far, and across how many start-ups?

We have funded over 1,300 start-ups, which is the highest in the world by any government. The ELEVATE programme is well-trenched with strong frameworks for these start-ups, which sets us apart. We don't just concentrate on capital, but also give them mentorship, access to our incubators, accelerators, and access to other countries through our Market Access Programme and Global Innovation Alliance. We also now have a special trust for wo-



men entrepreneurs, for start-ups beyond Bengaluru, and for start-ups that solve problems for the government.

We have declared the next 10 years as a 'Deep Tech Decade', wherein we have pledged more than ₹600 crore from the government and another ₹600 crore from private players into deep-tech companies. Here, the grant is up to ₹1 crore. In our first cohort, we have received submissions from 937 deep-tech start-ups, which we'll evaluate soon.

What progress has been made so far in fostering development across regions beyond Bengaluru?

Out of the last 31 GCCs that have come in, eight-nine

have moved beyond Bengaluru. We have also brought in the ₹1,000 crore Local Economic Accelerator Programme, where we are considering these towns as a cluster. Based on the location, geography and demography, we are fostering start-ups and incubators there. For instance, in Kalburgi, we are focusing on agritech, while in Hubballi-Belagavi-Dharwad, we are focusing on manufacturing and allied sectors.

Regarding the ban on social media for children under 16, what progress has been made so far?

The idea is to regulate social media usage. We have set up a committee. India has over 1.8 crore people below the age of 17. They are on social media in one form or another. More than 67 per cent are exposed to inappropriate content and images. While we are promoting digital learning across the state, we need to be careful because banning social media usage outright will push kids to unregulated websites. Educational institutions, parents and social media platforms need to join hands with us to be more responsive and responsible. Ultimately, it is about social media companies' public policies also.

500 years ago this day — a pivotal moment in Indian history

Despite Lodhi's confidence in his greater numbers and war elephants, Babur's innovative tactics led to a swift defeat for the Sultan

M Ramesh
Chennai

The Sultan was confident. His army easily outnumbered the adversary. And he had several hundreds of war elephants, a formidable force. Besides, he was on home turf, while the enemy came from afar.

The Sultan was nonchalant, sensing a quick and easy victory. He couldn't have been more wrong.

He had underestimated the adversary, who inherited a small kingdom, called Fergana, at the age of 12 and spent all his teen years in battles to keep it.

War was in his blood — genes of fighting came from the great conqueror Timur, from his father's side, and another great conqueror, Ghengis Khan, from his mother's. At 21, he had taken an army and captured Kabul.

Maybe the Sultan knew of his enemy's history, maybe he didn't. But the events of the battleground indicate that he knew little of the 43-year-old enemy's war tactics. By midday of April 21, 1526, Sultan Ibrahim Lodhi was killed; Zahir-ud-din Muhammad Babur seized Delhi, ending the 320-year-old Delhi Sul-



HISTORIC ENCOUNTER. The battle not only reshaped India's political landscape but also set the stage for centuries of Mughal rule

tanate, and established the Mughal empire.

FAMED BATTLES

That was the First Battle of Panipat.

Panipat, which lies 100 km north of Delhi in today's Haryana — said to be one of the five cities (*Prasthas*) established by the *Pandavas*, it would become the site of two more famed such encounters — is geography-made for battles.

The vast expansive,

open fields could house tens of thousands of soldiers and animals. Some 20 km away, Yamuna River provided enough water.

Marauding invaders from the northwest had to pass through Panipat to reach Delhi; it was just at the right distance for Delhi rulers to stop them, while still not being far from home.

Historians such as Satish Chandra and VD Mahajan have accepted the descriptions and averments

in Babur's memoirs, *Tuzuk-i-Baburi* (aka *Baburnama*) as history. It is mostly from those memoirs that we get to know about the fateful First Battle of Panipat that turned the flow of Indian history.

CANNONS AND GUNS

Babur brought in a few battle tricks that Ibrahim Lodhi never expected. The first was field artillery — cannons and guns — behind a moving fortifica-

tion of carts (*araba*) chained together. The thunder of the cannons panicked Lodhi's war elephants; faced with smoke, noise and the cart-protected gun line ahead, many turned back and ran straight into Lodhi's own ranks.

EFFECTIVE TACTIC

Alongside, Babur employed a tactic called *tulughma*, sending fast horsemen on the sides to encircle Lodhi's army — an age-old strategy, but employed effectively.

In a matter of a few hours, the Delhi Sultanate, established by the Mamluk (Slave Dynasty) in 1206, crumbled, humbled by the underdogs.

Five centuries later, it is perhaps fun to reflect over the course that Indian history might have taken if Babur had not come to India or had been defeated in the First Battle of Panipat.

First of all, there is little chance that he would not have come to India. Having tasted success in Kabul and made the city his base, Babur had been eyeing the rich Delhi Sultanate. But the winds also blew in his favour.

Historians Satish Chandra (*Medieval India*) and

Abraham Eraly note that Ibrahim Lodhi was a very unpopular man.

Afghan satraps under him, such as Daulat Khan Lodhi (who was the governor of Punjab) and Alam Khan Lodhi (Ibrahim's uncle) resented the rigid ruler of Delhi because of excessive Delhi control and their own ambitions.

Like cats inviting a monkey to settle a division of bread, they invited Babur — apparently in the belief that the man from Kabul will defeat Ibrahim Lodhi and go back home.

So, if Babur had not come, the Delhi Sultanate would likely have broken into pieces, either during or after Ibrahim Lodhi, leaving room and time for regional powers and the Rajput kings.

REASON TO RISE

Consequently, the Maratha empire, which rose to resist the Mughals, might never have had a reason to rise.

The Marathas, local chiefs under the Sultanate, are likely to have become several small kingdoms.

Whether or not the situation would have led to the same conditions that made the British smack their lips looking at India, is a matter wide open to speculation.

TCS case: Accused linked assaults to not wearing *burqa*, says engineer

Press Trust of India
Nashik

From derogatory slurs against religion to a team leader's inappropriate touch during training sessions, a woman engineer at a Nashik unit of Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) has revealed in harrowing detail the alleged harassment and religious coercion she faced at the office of the IT major.

In a chilling statement, which is part of one of nine FIRs, the complainant alleged that her harassers justified violence against women as a consequence of not wearing *burqas* and made derogatory remarks about Hindu deities.

MENTAL HARASSMENT

A Special Investigation Team (SIT) of Nashik Police has arrested eight persons, including a female operations manager, by registering nine FIRs after allegations of exploitation, attempt of forceful conversion, hurting religious sentiments, molestation and mental harassment of female employees at the TCS unit came to light. The Nashik police have formed three teams to trace another accused, Nida Khan. These teams have been

dispatched to various places, and one of them landed in Mumbai near Thane, officials said.

The victim, in her statement, alleged a prolonged pattern of sexual harassment, stalking, and intentional insults to religious sentiments at the hands of five accused between June 2025 and March 2026.

DEROGATORY REMARKS

She has claimed that one of the accused allegedly made derogatory remarks about Hindu deities and even suggested that "rapes take place because women do not wear *burqas*".

The woman employee claimed that her team leader touched her inappropriately on the pretext of formal training, and she was similarly molested by another accused in the pantry of the office.

Meanwhile, a local court on Monday did not grant interim protection from arrest to Khan, directing the police to submit their response to her plea by April 27.

During the hearing on Monday, her lawyer, Rahul Kasliwal, pressed for interim relief, which would have given her protection from arrest until her main plea was decided by the court.

